Fathers in Office, Sons in Jobs: Intergenerational Returns to Local Political Office

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Abstract

How does entry into local political office affect the long-run labor-market outcomes of officeholders' children, and what role do merit-based civil service institutions play? To study these questions, I construct a new dataset by digitizing rosters of township, village, and city officials in early twentieth-century Ohio and linking them to full-count U.S. censuses. This allows me to trace their adult children's labor-market outcomes from 1900 to 1940. Using a matched difference-in-differences design, I find that fathers' entry into office increases sons' occupational income score and white-collar employment, with gains persisting for decades after fathers leave office. In 1940, officials' sons earn about 13% more in annual wage income than their matched counterparts, while effects on daughters are more limited in this period of low female labor force participation. These gains are driven by increased access to both public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar jobs. Public-sector gains are particularly larger where local officials have greater hiring discretion and for sons with lower pre-office occupational standing. Exploiting the staggered adoption of municipal civil service reforms across cities, I find that civil service reforms do not eliminate the intergenerational political advantages. Instead, sons' private-sector white-collar gains become significantly larger when fathers enter office after the reform.

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1 Introduction

Access to good jobs shapes workers' career trajectories and lifetime earnings. Yet access to these opportunities depends not only on workers' qualifications but also on employers' hiring decisions. Political influence has long played a role in these decisions, particularly in the public sector, where politicians have used their discretion over hiring to favor supporters and relatives. Such practices range from the historical "spoils system" (Wilson, 1961) to discretionary appointments today. Political influence could also extend beyond government employment, as private firms may favor politically connected individuals.[1]

It is well documented that politicians' relatives have better labor market outcomes while politicians are in office (Fafchamps and Labonne, 2017; Gagliarducci and Manacorda, 2020; Folke et al., 2017). But less is known if these advantages persist long after politicians leave office, particularly when officeholding is relatively brief. It is also unclear to what extent institutions designed to curb political favoritism can limit these advantages. Concerns about political favoritism have motivated institutional reforms, including anti-nepotism restrictions and merit-based civil service systems, that constrain politicians' discretion over public-sector hiring. While these rules may restrict preferential access to government jobs, they do not directly constrain hiring decisions in the private sector. This raises two related questions: how does entry into political office shape the long-run labor market outcomes of their family members and how do these advantages respond to merit-based institutions aiming to curb political discretion in the public sector?

In this paper, I study how a parent's entry into local political office affects their adult children's long-run labor-market outcomes and how merit-based civil service reform shapes these effects. By focusing on children who were already adults when their parents entered office, I examine how parental officeholding shapes existing labor-market trajectories, rather than effects operating through changes in childhood investments. I study these questions in the context of township, village, and city officials in early twentieth-century Ohio. This historical setting offers two advantages. First, historical full-count censuses allow me to trace children's labor-market outcomes over several decades, including long after their parents leave the office. Second, the early twentieth century coincided with the Progressive Era's efforts to combat political patronage and

[1]For example, relatives of members of Congress in the United States were employed as lobbyists by private firms (Fallis and Keating, 2012). JPMorgan Chase and Credit Suisse faced investigation and enforcement actions for hiring relatives of government officials to obtain business opportunities (U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, 2016; U.S. Department of Justice, 2018).

corruption in local governments. Civil service reforms seek to replace the spoils system, under which local government employment was controlled by officials, with merit-based hiring and promotion. Ohio is part of this broader movement toward merit-based public employment. Local governments adopted municipal civil service reform at different times, providing variation to examine how restrictions on political discretion in public employment shape the labor-market advantages associated with parental officeholding.

I construct a new dataset by digitizing the *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers*, covering approximately 180,000 office-year observations across more than 2,000 township, village, and city governments between 1912 and 1929. The rosters include a broad range of positions, from city mayors to township trustees and other administrative, legislative, and judicial officials. This broad coverage allows me to examine advantages across different types of local offices and levels of government, rather than focusing only on prominent politicians. I then link these officials to the full-count U.S. Censuses to recover their own demographic information, identify their children and trace their outcomes from 1900 to 1940 using the Census Tree Project crosswalks developed by Buckles et al. (2025). Because local officials during this period were overwhelmingly male, I focus on the effects of fathers' entry into political office. I examine outcomes for sons and daughters separately, given the relatively low female labor force participation during this period.

The main identification challenge is selection into political office that fathers who become local officials may differ systematically from those who do not in ways that also affect their children's labor-market outcomes. To address this concern, I employ a matched difference-in-differences design that compares changes in the labor-market outcomes of officials' adult children with those of observationally similar individuals without a politician father, before and after officials' entry into office. I match individuals based on detailed characteristics of both fathers and children measured in the closest pre-office census, including demographic, geographic, and occupational characteristics. The matched sample is well balanced on observed pre-office characteristics, including those not used in the matching procedure. I then estimate a difference-in-differences model in the matched sample. Event-study estimates show no evidence of differential pre-trends between officials' children and their matched counterparts, supporting the plausibility of the parallel trends assumption.

I find that fathers' entry into local political office generates persistent labor-market advantages for their adult sons. Sons' occupational income scores, a proxy for earnings using the median income associated with each occupation in the 1950 Census, increase by approximately 2.3 percent after their fathers enter office, accompanied by a 2 percentage

point increase in white-collar employment.[2] These gains persist for decades, even though their fathers typically hold office for around four years. Using wage income reported in the 1940 Census, sons of officials earn approximately 13 percent more annually than their matched counterparts, an increase comparable to the returns to two additional years of education. Effects on daughters are more limited in this period of low female labor-force participation. Fathers' officeholding does not significantly increase daughters' labor-force participation or improve their labor-market outcomes on average, although I find suggestive evidence of gains in occupational income among working daughters.

The results are robust. To address concerns about potential selection into politics based on unobservables, I conduct two complementary analyses. First, I compare sons of officials who entered office in 1918 with those who entered in 1922. By the 1920 Census, only the former had assumed office, allowing me to compare families whose fathers eventually held political office within a short window of time. Second, using candidates' names and electoral returns collected from historical newspapers, I compare sons of the lowest-vote winners and highest-vote losers. Both analyses yield positive effect on occupational income score of fathers' officeholding. The main findings are also robust to alternative specifications, outcome measures, and sample restrictions.

How does fathers' entry into local political office improve sons' occupational outcomes? One important channel is increased access to public-sector employment. Fathers' entry into office increases their sons' probability of working in the public sector by about 1.2 percentage points, roughly 70 percent relative to the control-group mean. Several patterns of evidence are consistent with political nepotism in public employment. First, the increase is concentrated in local governments and postal employment, with no corresponding increase in state or other federal employment, which are beyond the reach of local officials. Second, the public-sector advantage is substantially larger for sons of officials in village and township governments, where civil service constraints are weaker and officials have greater discretion over hiring. Third, the increase in public employment is particularly larger for sons with lower occupational income before their fathers start the office, consistent with political nepotism that fathers' officeholding facilitates access to government jobs for less-advantaged sons.

The benefits of fathers' entry into political office are not just confined to jobs within the government. In fact, approximately 80% of the increase in sons' white-collar employment occurs in the private sector. These private-sector white-collar employment gains are

[2]Individual income information is not available until the 1940 Census.

particularly larger for sons of officials in city governments. The increase in private-sector white-collar employment is concentrated in wholesale, retail trade, finance, insurance, and real estate, sectors where firms frequently interact with local governments through licensing, regulation, and other administrative decisions.

The presence of advantages in both the public and private sectors raises an important question about the effectiveness of merit-based civil service reforms: How do merit-based civil service institutions shape the intergenerational labor-market advantages associated with political officeholding? To examine this question, I exploit the staggered adoption of municipal civil service reforms across Ohio cities and compare the effects of fathers' entry into office before and after reform. I find that the reform did not fully eliminate the intergenerational labor market advantages. However, the composition of these advantages differs substantially. The estimated effect on sons' public-sector employment declines from 2.6 percentage points before reform to nearly zero after the reform, although the difference is imprecisely estimated in the small sample. In contrast, the effect on private-sector white-collar employment increases significantly, shifting from a negative point estimate before the reform to a positive 6.6 percentage points under civil service. These findings suggest that merit-based civil service reforms may redirect the channels through which intergenerational political advantages arise rather than eliminate these advantages.

Finally, I explore the broader distributional implications of intergenerational political advantages. I find that a greater presence of officials' sons in public employment is associated with higher subsequent income inequality in townships, but not in cities. While this evidence is descriptive, it suggests that political advantages may have broader distributional implications in smaller local labor markets.

This paper contributes to three strands of literature. First, it contributes to the literature on the private returns to political office. A growing literature documents economic benefits for officeholders themselves (Fisman et al., 2014; Eggers and Hainmueller, 2009) and their family members (Gagliarducci and Manacorda, 2020; Fafchamps and Labonne, 2017). More closely related, Folke et al. (2017) study newly appointed mayors in Sweden and find earnings gains among their children, with suggestive evidence that these gains persist 9–11 years after their parents assume office. However, they find no evidence that the gains arise through municipal public-sector employment. In contrast, I find that public-sector employment is an important channel of intergenerational political advantages, particularly where local officials face fewer constraints on hiring discretion. This contrast suggests that institutions governing public employment may shape how political advantages are transmitted across generations and motivates the examination of civil service reforms in

the paper. The historical setting also allows me to study the effect decades after the office. Relatedly, Ho (2025) studies historical U.S. congressional and gubernatorial elections and finds temporary increases in children's occupational income following electoral victories.[3] I contribute to this literature by studying a broad range of relatively ordinary local political offices, and showing that even brief periods of officeholding can generate lasting labor-market advantages for adult children, with gains persisting for decades after fathers leave office.

Second, the paper contributes to the literature on public employment and civil service reform. Existing literature shows that politicians may allocate resources on the basis of political loyalty and personal connections, with public employment as one important margin (Cruz et al., 2017; Leucht, 2023; Colonnelli et al., 2020). In particular, Colonnelli et al. (2020) show that political connections influence public-sector hiring and bureaucratic quality. I add an intergenerational dimension by showing that fathers' officeholding improves sons' access to public employment, particularly where officials have greater hiring discretion. I further contribute to the literature on merit-based civil service reform (Aneja and Xu, 2024; Moreira and Pérez, 2024; Ujhelyi, 2014; Kuipers and Sahn, 2023) by examining how restrictions on political discretion over public hiring shape these advantages. My finding highlights the limit of such reform that the reform redirects where the political advantages arise rather than eliminate them.[4]

Finally, this paper contributes to the broader literature on intergenerational mobility and the transmission of economic advantage (Barrios-Fernández et al., 2026; Kramarz and Skans, 2014; Long and Ferrie, 2013; Mocetti, 2016). While much of this literature examines the persistence of economic status across generations, I study how a parent's acquisition of political power affects the labor-market trajectories of children who have already reached adulthood. In contrast to the intergenerational transmission of political office itself (Dal Bó et al., 2009), I show that political power can generate lasting economic advantages for the next generation even without children entering political office.

The rest of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 provides the institutional background and describes the data. Section 3 describes the empirical design and Section 4

[3]Members of Congress are highly selected in terms of family background and economic attainment (Thompson et al., 2019), whereas the local officials in my setting come from a broad range of occupational backgrounds.

[4]In a similar spirit, related studies document how the effects of civil service reforms could be limited by their reach. Moreira and Pérez (2024) find that federal civil service reform did not improve the cost-effectiveness of customs revenue collection, with the appointment of top managers remaining outside the reform's reach. Ujhelyi (2014) find that state-level civil service reforms led to a reallocation of expenditures away from state bureaucracies and toward lower-level governments.

presents the main results. Section 5 explores the potential mechanism. Section 6 examines the role of civil service institutions. Section 7 explores the downstream effect and Section 8 concludes.

2 Background and Data

2.1 Institutional Background

2.1.1 Local Government and Political Offices in Ohio

This paper focuses on township, village, and city governments in Ohio in the early twentieth century. These forms of government differed in scale and administrative structure. Township government had a relatively simple structure, centered on a board of trustees together with a clerk and a treasurer.[5] Municipal governments had broader and more differentiated administrative structures. Cities and villages were formally distinguished by population: under the 1912 Ohio Constitution, municipal corporations with populations of at least 5,000 were classified as cities and those below 5,000 as villages. The same constitutional reform granted municipalities home-rule authority and allowed them to adopt charters governing their own institutional organization. As a result, the organization of municipal government was not uniform across places, particularly among cities, which could operate under different governmental structures and contained different sets of offices. Villages generally had simpler structures, with offices such as mayor, council member, clerk, marshal, and street commissioner, while cities contained a wider range of specialized officials, departments, boards, and commissions.

The *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers* cover a broad set of local offices that comprise the principal elected and administrative positions through which local governments were governed and operated. These include executive, legislative, judicial, fiscal, and public-works positions, although the specific set of offices differed across cities, villages, and townships. Most positions were elected offices with election taking place every two years. Some administrative and professional positions were filled by appointment. Appendix Table B1 reports the offices observed in the rosters.

Throughout the paper, I define local officeholding based on the positions reported in the *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers*. This baseline definition therefore

[5]The office of township treasurer was abolished after 1924 with township clerk assuming the treasurer's duties.

captures formally designated local public offices, including both the elected and a small set of appointed offices. In section 4.4, I explore the results using only the sample of core elected offices and the result is not driven by the selection of the officials list.

Officials' responsibilities differed across offices and forms of government, but together they covered a broad range of local public functions. Township officials administered matters including roads, township finances, and local records, while municipal officials had responsibilities spanning public safety, streets and public works, utilities, finance, and law. Depending on the position, officials could make legislative or administrative decisions, manage public expenditures and projects, supervise government departments, and appoint or oversee public employees. Their responsibilities over public works, utilities, and local regulation also brought local governments into contact with private economic activity.

2.1.2 Public Employment and Civil-Service Reform

Before the widespread adoption of merit-based civil-service systems, public employment in the United States was often influenced by patronage and political recommendations (Wilson, 1961). Civil service reform was designed in part to reduce political influence over public employment by formalizing recruitment procedures. Under the merit system, civil service commissions oversee recruitment through public vacancy announcements and examinations. Politicians therefore have less discretion over public-sector appointments, making it harder to allocate government positions through patronage, personal ties, or political recommendations. The Pendleton Act of 1883 introduced merit-based recruitment for part of the federal bureaucracy, after which civil service institutions gradually spread to state and municipal governments.

Municipal adoption of civil service reform was staggered. Ohio progressively expanded merit-based civil-service requirements in the early twentieth century. The 1912 Ohio Constitution required appointments and promotions in the civil service of the state, counties, and cities to be based on merit and fitness, ascertained where practicable through competitive examinations (Ohio Constitution, 1912). Notably, this constitutional mandate applied to cities but did not extend to villages or townships. Among municipalities, however, the establishment and implementation of civil-service systems remained uneven. Municipalities differed substantially in the timing of adoption and implementation of the civil service system (Kuipers and Sahn, 2023). I therefore distinguish between the statewide constitutional mandate and the effective local adoption

and implementation of a municipal civil service system. Figure A4 plots the distribution of reform timing across municipalities in Ohio using data from Kuipers and Sahn (2023). There is substantial variation in adoption time: for example, Urbana adopted civil service in 1887; Cleveland, Cincinnati, and Columbus in 1910; Toledo in 1916; Akron in 1920; and Hamilton in 1928.

2.2 Data and Descriptive Statistics

2.2.1 Ohio Roster of Township and Municipal Officers

My main source of data is *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers* (Ohio Secretary of State, 1929) (hereafter, the rosters). The rosters are published biennially by the Ohio Secretary of State and provide a listing of local officials organized by county, locality (township, village, and city), and office. I digitized 9 consecutive rosters covering the years 1912 through 1929.[6] Figure C1, C2, and C3 show the example pages of the rosters. In total, the dataset includes 179,952 year-office observations spanning offices in 95 cities, 862 villages, and 1,518 townships.

2.2.2 Linking the Rosters to the Census

To obtain demographic characteristics and intergenerational information for local officials, I link the individuals listed in the rosters to the full-count U.S. censuses (Ruggles et al., 2024).

I link each official listed in the rosters to the contemporaneous full-count censuses based on their name and location using an automated procedure that proceeds in two stages. I first attempt to link each official to the closest pre-office census. For example, officials in the 1914 roster are initially matched to individuals in the 1910 census. A match is defined when there is a unique individual in the census who satisfies three baseline criteria: (1) the same first and last name; (2) residence in the same county as the roster record; and (3) being at least 25 years old at the time of entry into office.[7] If multiple candidates meet these conditions, I incorporate additional criteria: middle name consistency and locality,

[6] Volumes were published before 1912 and after 1929, but not in a continuous series. I restrict attention to 1912 - 1929 in order to maintain a consecutive series of rosters.

[7] For some officials, the rosters only reported the initial of their first name. In this case, I also link them to the censuses based on the initial of the first name. As a robustness check, I show that the main results remain when excluding links for officials that report only initials of their first names.

i.e., township or municipality, of residence in the census.[8] A match is defined if there is a unique individual record in the census that satisfies the criteria (1) − (3) and (4) that there is no conflict in the middle name; or satisfies the criteria (1) − (4) and (5) that the individual resides in the same town or municipality as the office locality recorded in the roster.

If no match is found in the closest pre-office census, I then turn to the closest post-office census. For instance, an official in the 1914 Roster who cannot be linked in the 1910 census will then be linked to potential records in the 1920 census. The same sequence of matching criteria and tie-breaking rules is applied until either a unique match is found or no eligible candidate remains.

Using this procedure, I successfully link approximately 70% of the office-year records in the rosters to individuals in the full-count censuses.[9] Between 1912 and 1928, I matched 57,936 unique officials in the rosters. Table B2 reports the linkage rates in detail, disaggregated by roster year and form of government.

2.2.3 Collecting Information on Winning and Losing Candidates

To complement the study, I construct a separate dataset of local election candidates. Starting from the names of officials listed in the rosters, I search historical newspapers around election dates for coverage of local elections. Figure A2 describes this procedure and Figure A3 provides an example of such election coverage. Whenever election coverage is available, I digitize candidates' names, offices, locality, and votes. This procedure allows me to get information on losing candidates, who are not recorded in the rosters.

The resulting dataset covers around 290 races, mostly for city governments and races for mayors and council members. Although this sample is smaller than the Rosters-based sample, it provides a useful complementary source of variation for comparing winning and losing candidates.

[8]The locality (township or municipality) information is obtained from the Census Place Project (Berkes et al., 2023).

[9]This linkage rate is higher than what is commonly achieved in historical census linkage, likely reflecting the detailed name and location information available for local officials in the rosters. It may also partly reflect the fact that the sample is overwhelmingly white, a group for which historical census linkage rates tend to be higher. This linking rate is comparable to that reported by Abramitzky et al. (2024), who link university faculty rosters to the full-count censuses.

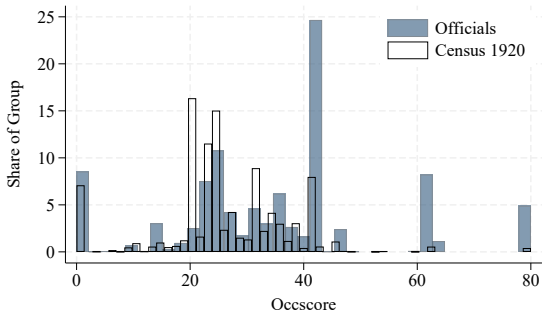
2.2.4 Descriptive: Characteristics of Local Officials

Having linked local officials in the rosters to the full-count censuses, I obtain their demographic characteristics and pre-office economic backgrounds. Table B3 reports summary statistics for local officials (Panel A) and compares them to the general population of Ohio from the 1920 Census (Panel B). Relative to the population, local officials are overwhelmingly male and less likely to be foreign-born. They also have higher occupational income scores, which is a measure of median income observed in the 1950 Census by each occupation,[10] prior to entering office, indicating positive selection into local political positions. The average official enters office approximately at age 47, suggesting that local officeholding typically occurs later in the working life rather than at labor market entry.

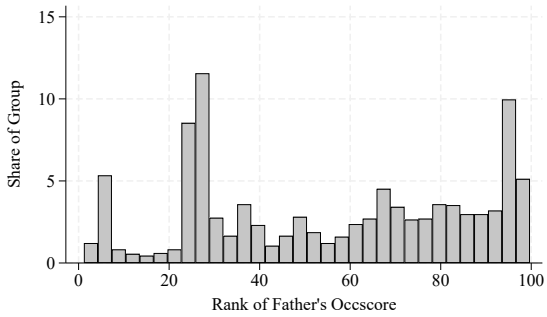
Figure 1 provides a more detailed view of officials' economic backgrounds by plotting the distribution of pre-office occupational income scores and family background separately for city, village, and township governments. Panels A, C, and E compare officials' pre-office occupational income distributions to those of the working-age male population. Across all three settings, officials tend to come from occupations with higher income scores than the average population, though they are not concentrated in the extreme upper tail of the distribution. This pattern is most pronounced in cities, where officials' occupational distribution is clearly shifted to the right relative to the general population. In contrast, township officials are concentrated in the lower and middle portions of the occupational distribution, substantially overlapping with the average male population and only a limited presence in the upper tail. Village officials fall between these two cases, exhibiting modest positive selection relative to the population in terms of occupational background.

Panels B, D, and F examine officials' family backgrounds, measured by the percentile rank of their fathers' occupational income scores within their fathers' cohort when these officials were young. City officials tend to come from more advantaged families, although not concentrated at the very top of the distribution. Village and township officials, by contrast, are substantially more likely to come from families with modest occupational backgrounds. Taken together, these patterns indicate that while local officials were positively selected relative to the general population, especially in cities, township and village offices were accessible to individuals from a wide range of socioeconomic backgrounds rather than being dominated by economic elites.

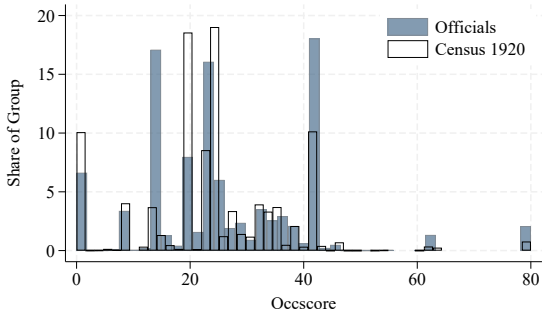
[10] The income information is not available until the 1940 Census.



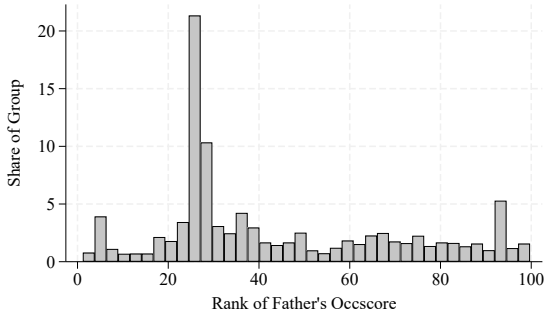
A. Occscore: City



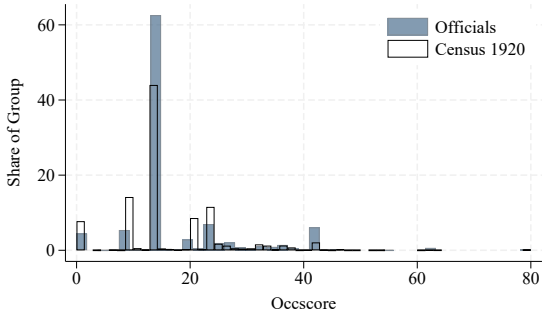
B. Family Background: City



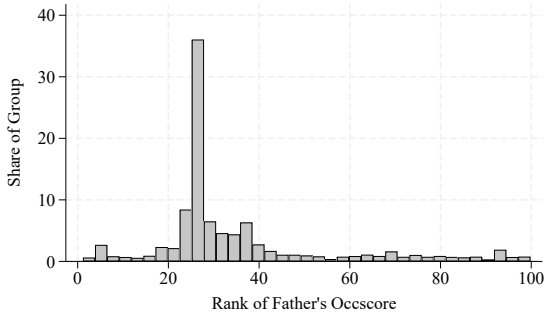
C. Occscore: Village



D. Family Background: Village



E. Occscore: Township



F. Family Background: Township

Figure 1. Distribution of Officials' Pre-office Occupation and Family Background

Note: This figure describes the economic backgrounds of male local officials separately for city, village, and township governments. Panels A, C, and E plot the distribution of officials' pre-office occupational income scores and the corresponding distribution among men ages 25–65 in the 1920 Census. Panels B, D, and F plot officials' family backgrounds, measured by the percentile rank of their fathers' occupational income scores within their fathers' birth cohorts.

In the Appendix, Figure C4 presents a breakdown of officials' characteristics by year and form of local government, showing that the patterns of pre-office occupational income score for officials are relatively stable over time.

2.2.5 Linking Officials to Their Family

To get the intergenerational information for local officials, I link officials to their children using census-to-census crosswalks from the Census Tree Project (CTP) (Buckles et al., 2025). I first trace each official across earlier census waves to periods when their children are likely to reside in the same household. This allows me to identify children directly from the household and recover child identifiers. After identifying children, I use the CTP crosswalks to follow them forward across census waves and construct their labor market outcomes in the full-count censuses from 1900 through 1940. This procedure enables me to observe children's occupational trajectories over much of their working lives and therefore to study the longer-run impact of fathers' officeholding on children's labor market outcomes. Because the analysis relies on successful linkage across census waves, I examine potential selection from differential observability in Section 4.3 and find no evidence that officials' sons and their matched counterparts have a differential probability of being observed in the linked census sample.

2.2.6 Outcome Variables

The main outcomes of interest are labor-market outcomes, specifically earnings, occupation, and sector of employment. Because the full-count censuses did not collect individual earnings information until 1940, I proxy for earnings using the occupational income score measure (Occscore). The Occscore measure is constructed by assigning to each occupation the median income observed in the 1950 Census. The Occscore measure has two limitations: it does not capture within-occupation variation in individual earnings, and it does not reflect changes in the relative earnings of occupations over time. The latter limitation is difficult to address given the absence of individual earnings data for the pre-1940 period. To partially address the former limitation, I use a complementary measure as a robustness check in Section E.3, the Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) scores developed by Saavedra and Twinam (2020), which adjusts occupational earnings by incorporating industry and demographic composition. It is important to note that both the Occscore and LIDO scores provide only occupation-based proxies for labor market outcomes rather than direct measures of earnings. To complement the measure of earning, I use individual wage income reported in the 1940 Census.

I also examine the types of occupations in which individuals work. I classify reported occupations into four broad categories: white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and

agricultural occupations. To study the employment channels underlying the occupational changes, I construct indicators for public- and private-sector employment.

3 Research Design

As local officials could differ from the general population, a simple comparison between children of local officials and children of non-local officials would yield biased estimates of the intergenerational effects of officeholding. To address this concern, I employ a matched difference-in-differences design that compares changes in outcomes for children whose fathers enter local office to those of observationally similar children whose fathers do not.

3.1 Matching

My sample consists of individuals who had reached working age in the census year prior to their fathers' entry into office. For the main analysis, I focus on child-census observations in which the individuals reside in Ohio.[11] I restrict the sample to the children of officials who began officeholding between 1914 and 1928.[12]

I implement nearest-neighbor matching to pair each child of officials (treated) with a comparable individual whose father does not appear as a local official in the rosters (control). Matching is conducted at the closest pre-office census ($t = -1$). To reduce the likelihood that the control group includes local officials omitted from the rosters, I exclude potential control families in which the father is employed in the public sector at $t = -1$. This restriction uses only pre-office information and is motivated by incomplete reporting of some local offices in the rosters, which I discuss further in Section 4.3. For each treated individual, I select control individuals of the same gender and race, residing in the same county, born in the same state/country, having the same immigration family background, same literacy status, and having the smallest Mahalanobis distance based on age, pre-office occupational income score, father's age, and father's pre-office occupational income score. Matching is conducted with replacement, so the same control individual may be matched to more than one treated individual. When a control is used for multiple treated individuals, it enters the analysis separately for each matched set and is assigned

[11] Because the CTP links allow me to observe individuals outside Ohio, I examine whether fathers' officeholding differentially affects sons' subsequent out-of-state residence in Section 4.3 and find no evidence that it does.

[12] Because the roster data are truncated between 1912 and 1928, I exclude children of officials appearing in the 1912−1913 Rosters, as their fathers may have entered office before 1912.

the office-entry timing of the corresponding treated father. Thus, a reused control can have different matched-set-specific event times depending on the treated individual to whom it is compared. When multiple controls are tied at the minimum Mahalanobis distance for a treated individual, I keep all tied controls. If M_i controls are tied for treated individual i, each receives a matching weight of $1/M_i$ so that the total weight assigned to the controls associated with each treated individual equals one.

Table 1 reports balance tests for both targeted and non-targeted covariates in the matched sample. Children of officials and their matched controls are highly similar along observed demographic and family background characteristics. While there is a statistically significant difference in maternal literacy between the two groups, the magnitude of this difference is very small relative to the sample mean.

3.2 Econometric Specification

To identify the intergenerational impact of fathers' officeholding, I estimate the following difference-in-differences specification using the matched sample:

$$y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + \beta_1(\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}) + \beta_2 \text{Post}_{it} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \tag{1}$$

where i denotes individual, b age bins defined in five-year intervals, c county, and t census year. y_{ibct} is the outcome of interest for individual i in year t. $\text{Office}_{j(i)}$ is an indicator equal to one if individual i's father j ever holds local office. Post_{it} equals zero if i's father j hasn't started the term in census year t and one in all subsequent census years after the office entry. The specification therefore captures changes in children's outcomes following fathers' first entry into the local office. For matched controls, Post_{it} is assigned based on the timing of their matched treated counterpart. The specification includes individual fixed effects α_i, age-bin-at-year fixed effects θ_{bt},[13] county fixed effect μ_c and census year fixed effect γ_t. The regression is weighted by the matching weights to account for cases in which a treated individual is matched to multiple controls. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

To estimate the dynamic effect, I estimate the following event-study specification:

$$y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_1^k (\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \mathbf{1}\{t = k\}) + \sum_k \beta_2^k \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \tag{2}$$

[13]The birth cohort fixed effects will be absorbed by the individual fixed effect. Age-bin-at-year fixed effects flexibly control for age profiles, varying within-individual for different census year t. I categorize every five years into one bin.

Table 1. Balance Table for Matched Sample: $t = -1$

	Children of Officials		Matched Individuals		Difference Treated - Control	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Mean	Obs	Mean	Obs	Diff	SE
Targeted variables						
Male	0.519	21,257	0.520	31,780	-0.000	0.005
White	0.998	21,257	0.998	31,780	-0.000	0.001
Foreignborn	0.002	21,257	0.002	31,780	0.000	0.001
Immigrant Parent	0.070	21,257	0.069	31,780	0.001	0.004
Literate	0.996	21,257	0.996	31,780	0.000	0.001
Age	24.941	21,257	24.901	31,780	0.039	0.072
Occscore	12.178	21,257	12.153	31,780	0.025	0.133
Father Literate	0.992	21,257	0.992	31,780	0.000	0.001
Father Occscore	22.186	21,257	21.978	31,780	0.208	0.162
Father Age	54.270	21,257	54.348	31,780	-0.078	0.101
Non-targeted variables						
Married	0.460	21,257	0.458	31,780	0.002	0.005
Num of Kids	0.656	21,257	0.674	31,780	-0.018	0.013
Mother Literate	0.992	19,893	0.985	29,176	0.007***	0.002
Mother Occscore	0.454	19,893	0.393	29,176	0.060	0.045
Mother Age	50.467	19,893	50.329	29,176	0.138	0.107

Note: This table reports covariate balance between officials' adult children and their matched counterparts in the first pre-office Census $t = -1$.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

where $\mathbf{1}\{t = k\}$ are the event time dummies relative to fathers' office entry, with $k = -1$ corresponding to the first pre-office census and $k = 1$ to the first post-office census. This specification allows me to assess both pre-trends and the dynamic response of children's labor market outcomes following fathers' entry into office.

The key identification assumption is that in the absence of the fathers' entry into local office, the labor market evolution of officials' children should be the same as their matched counterparts. While this assumption is not directly testable, I assess its plausibility by examining pre-treatment trends in the event-study analysis. The parallel pre-trends in the pre-office years (Figure 2) support the validity of the research design. Section 4.3 further

discusses potential threats to identification and presents additional evidence addressing these concerns.

4 Main Results

This section examines how fathers' entry into local political office affects their adult children's labor market outcomes over the life cycle.

Before turning to the causal analysis of the intergenerational effect on labor market outcomes in Equation 1, I first document raw trends in occupational income scores for officials' children and their matched counterparts. Figure A1 plots average occupational income scores for sons and daughters of officials and their matched controls. In the pre-office period, the trajectories for treated and control individuals closely mirror each other for both sons and daughters. Note that although the matching is conducted at $t = -1$, occupational income scores remain balanced at $t = -2$, providing credibility for the quality of the matching. The close alignment of trends prior to fathers' office entry provides credibility for the identification assumption. Following fathers' entry into office, the trajectories diverge for sons. Sons of officials experience a sustained increase in occupational income relative to their matched counterparts. This advantage persists through at least the third post-office census, suggesting that even low-level political officeholding can generate long-lasting effects on children's career trajectories. In contrast, daughters show no comparable divergence in occupational income following fathers' office entry.

Because female labor force participation was relatively low during the early twentieth century,[14] this section explores the labor market effect by gender.

4.1 Effects on Sons' Labor-Market Outcomes

Table 2 examines the impact of fathers' officeholding on sons' labor market outcomes using the matched difference-in-differences specification. Columns (1) and (2) report estimates for sons' occupational income score. Column (1) reports the result without controlling for individual fixed effects. The small and insignificant coefficient of Office suggests that there is no difference in occupational income score between sons of officials and their matched

[14]The labor force participation rate for working-age (18-64) women is 22.44% and for working-age (18-64) men is 94.62% in Ohio, calculated using the 1920 Census.

counterparts before the father enters the office. After the office, the occupational income score for sons of officials increases by 2.7 percent compared to their matched counterparts. Column (2) includes individual fixed effects, comparing the change in occupational income score in the same individual before and after the office time. When partialling out the time-invariant differences across individuals, fathers' officeholding increases sons' income score by 2.3 percent.

Columns (3) to (6) explore occupational changes underlying this increase in occupational income score. I classify occupations into four categories: white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations. Fathers' officeholding significantly increases sons' probability of working in a white-collar occupation by 2 percentage points, about 10 percent relative to the control-group mean. At the same time, sons of officials become less likely to work in skilled blue-collar occupations, with little change in low-skill employment and a modest decline in agricultural work, although the effect is not statistically significant. These patterns indicate that the improvement in sons' occupational standing is driven primarily by a relative shift toward white-collar occupations, which on average have higher earnings.

Because the occupational income score captures only between-occupation differences and not within-occupation earnings variation, the true effect on earnings might be different if fathers' officeholding generates within-occupation benefits, which OCCSCORE cannot capture. To provide suggestive evidence on the magnitude of the income effects, I exploit wage income information available in the 1940 Census and compare the wage income of officials' sons and their matched counterparts. Column (7) shows that among sons with observed wage income in 1940, officials' sons earn approximately 13 percent more than their matched counterparts. This estimate comes from a cross-sectional comparison within matched pairs rather than the panel difference-in-differences specification used in Columns (1) - (6). The magnitude of the effect is comparable to returns from additional two years of schooling documented in the literature (Card, 1999; Psacharopoulos and Patrinos, 2018), suggesting that political officeholding confers non-trivial labor market advantages.

I next examine the dynamics of the effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' occupational outcomes by estimating the event-study specification in Equation 2. Figure 2 shows no evidence of differential pre-trends between sons of officials and their matched counterparts prior to fathers' office entry. In particular, the estimated coefficient in the pre-office period is very close to zero, supporting the identification assumption. Following fathers' office entry, sons' occupational income increases relative to their matched counterparts. The effect appears in the first post-office census and persists for at least two

Table 2. Intergenerational impact on sons' labor market outcomes

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.027***	0.023***	0.020***	-0.008*	-0.000	-0.007	
	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.006)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.005						0.129***
	(0.007)						(0.023)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.133	22.133	0.209	0.142	0.385	0.257	1287.692
R^2	0.160	0.715	0.686	0.575	0.544	0.638	0.610
Observations	81981	81981	84173	84173	84173	84173	11176

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900 – 1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (Mean of Occscore for Columns (1) – (2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)—(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

subsequent census decades. These longer-run effects generally outlast fathers' periods in office: fathers are observed holding office for approximately four years on average, substantially shorter than the horizon over which the occupational gains persist. The dynamic results therefore indicate that fathers' local officeholding shapes sons' longer-run occupational trajectories rather than generating gains only while fathers remain in office. Figure 3 further shows that the persistent increase in sons' occupational income score following their fathers' office entry is driven primarily by persistent increases in white-collar employment. The dynamic results indicate that fathers' local officeholding shapes sons' long-run occupational trajectories rather than producing temporary income gains.

Section E.2 explores the heterogeneity in the intergenerational effects of fathers' officeholding by sons' age at the time of fathers' office entry and by sibling composition.

Figure E6 examines the heterogeneity by sons' age when their fathers first enter office. There is not much heterogeneity for sons aged below 40 when their father starts the office and the effect of fathers' office declines to zero for sons who were already in their forties when their fathers entered office. Figure E7 explores heterogeneity by sibling composition. The effects are somewhat larger for first-born sons relative to later-born sons and for sons without sisters relative to sons with sisters, although the effects are not significantly different. And the effects do not vary by sibling size.

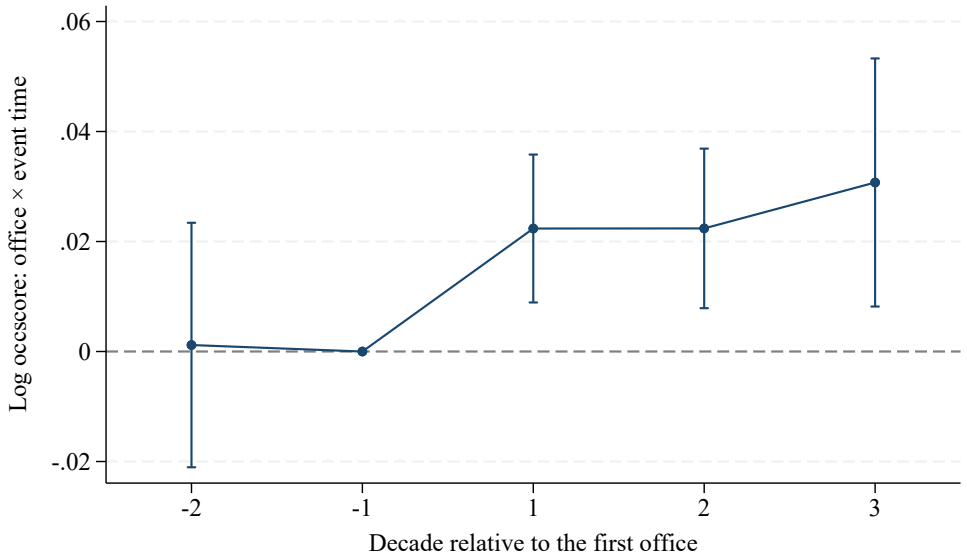


Figure 2. Dynamic Effect of Fathers' Officeholding on Sons' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

4.2 Effects on Daughters' Outcomes

This section examines the impact of fathers' officeholding on daughters' labor-market outcomes. This scenario is somewhat different compared to the analysis of sons. Female labor force participation was relatively low during the sample period, and women's labor force participation was closely related to life-cycle events such as marriage. I therefore first examine whether fathers' officeholding affects daughters' labor force participation and, conditional on working, their occupational outcomes. I then consider marriage as an alternative margin through which daughters might benefit from their fathers' political position.

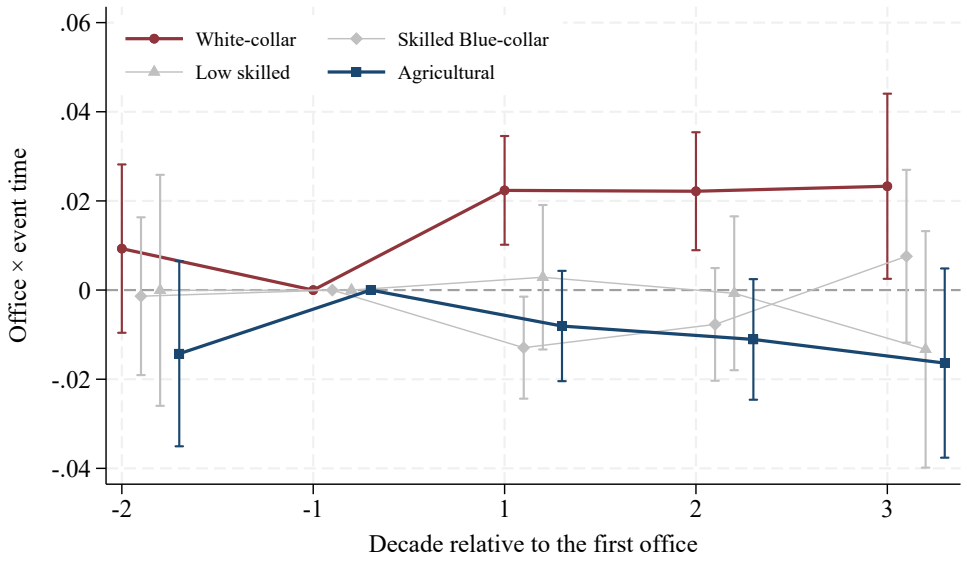


Figure 3. Dynamic Effect of Office on Sons' Occupational Category

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupation categories from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Table 3 reports the labor-market results. Column (1) shows no evidence that fathers' officeholding affects daughters' labor-force participation. The estimated effect is close to zero relative to a control-group labor force participation rate of 14.9 percent. Figure E1 presents the corresponding event-study estimates and shows no change in daughters' labor force participation after fathers' office entry.

Among daughters who work, Column (2) shows that working daughters of officials have occupational income scores approximately 3.1 percent higher than those of their matched counterparts. This estimate in magnitude is similar to, and if anything larger than, the corresponding effect for sons, although it is only marginally statistically significant. The occupation category outcomes provide less evidence of broad occupational upgrading. Columns (3) to (6) show no systematic shifts into white-collar work or away from skilled blue-collar, low-skilled, or agricultural occupations. The increase in OCCSCORE therefore appears to reflect changes within these broad occupational groups rather than a clear reallocation across them. Column (7) provides an additional comparison using wage income from the 1940 Census. The estimated wage advantage for working daughters of officials is positive and similar in magnitude to the corresponding estimate for sons, but it is imprecisely estimated and statistically insignificant.

The event study estimates reinforce this interpretation. Figure E2 shows that the increase in occupational standing among working daughters emerges only in later periods after fathers enter office, while Figure E3 shows little systematic change across broad occupational categories. These estimates should nevertheless be interpreted cautiously: unlike for sons, occupational outcomes are observed only for the relatively small and selected group of daughters who participate in the labor market.

To assess daughters' outcomes without conditioning on labor-force participation, Appendix Table E1 and Figure E4 assign an OCCSCORE of zero to nonworking daughters and estimates the effect in the full sample of working-age daughters. This outcome combines extensive margin of whether a daughter participates in market work and intensive margin of the occupational standing of daughters' jobs if they work, and should therefore be interpreted as an overall measure of daughters' labor market outcomes. Across alternative transformations of OCCSCORE and estimation methods, the estimates are small and statistically insignificant. Hence, the suggestive gains observed among working daughters do not translate into a detectable improvement in labor-market outcomes for daughters in general.

The limited evidence of gains in daughters' labor-market outcomes in general raises the possibility that fathers' officeholding might matter for daughters through a different margin. In a setting where female labor force participation is low, political status could instead improve daughters' economic position through marriage, for example by facilitating matches with more advantaged husbands. Appendix Section E.1.1 examines this possibility. Table E2 provides little evidence that fathers' officeholding leads to more advantageous marital matches along the dimensions observable in the census. Daughters whose fathers enter office are not more likely to be married to white-collar or public-sector husbands, and their husbands do not have significantly higher occupational income scores or come from families with higher occupational standing. I also examine whether fathers' officeholding subsequently improves the labor-market outcomes of sons-in-law. Figure E5 shows no systematic increase in sons-in-law's occupational income score following their fathers-in-law's entry into office.

Taken together, the evidence for daughters is more limited than for sons. Fathers' officeholding does not increase daughters' labor-force participation or improve their labor-market outcomes on average, although there is suggestive evidence of higher occupational standing among the selected group of daughters who work. Nor do the benefits appear to operate through more advantageous marital matches or improvements in sons-in-law's occupational outcomes. The remainder of the paper therefore focuses on sons, for whom

Table 3. Effects of Fathers' Officeholding on Daughters' Labor-Market Outcomes

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
	LFP	Log Occscore	White collar	Skilled blue collar	Low skill	Agricultural	Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	-0.003	0.031*	0.008	0.004	-0.007	-0.004	
	(0.006)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.008)	(0.018)	(0.005)	
Office$_{j(i)}$							0.132
							(0.154)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	0.149	22.128	0.646	0.021	0.319	0.015	803.614
R^2	0.514	0.752	0.794	0.567	0.784	0.622	0.728
Observations	91022	15764	15764	15764	15764	15764	2540

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on daughters' labor-market outcomes. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. The dependent variable in Column (1) is an indicator for labor-force participation. The dependent variable in Column (2) is log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), conditional on the working daughters. The dependent variables in Columns (3)–(6) are indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skilled, and agricultural occupations, respectively, also conditional on labor-force participation. These columns include matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed in the 1900–1940 Censuses; Column (1) excludes the 1900 Census because labor-force participation is not observed. Column (7) uses the 1940 Census and examines log wage income among matched daughters observed in the 1940 Census. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (Mean of Occscore for Column (2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

the labor-market effects are more consistently observed and can be examined in greater detail.

4.3 Validity of the Design

The key identification assumption is that in the absence of the fathers' entry into office, the labor market evolution of officials' children should be similar to their matched counterparts. Although this assumption cannot be tested directly, the event-study estimates provide no evidence of differential trends before office entry. I next consider several potential threats to this assumption, including selection into politics, measurement error, reverse causality, and spillovers to the comparison group.

Positive selection into politics. A potential concern is that fathers who enter politics may differ from matched counterparts in unobserved ways that also benefit their children. For example, political ambition, local standing, or preexisting social networks could both increase a father's likelihood of obtaining office and improve his son's labor market outcomes. In that case, the baseline estimates could partly reflect family characteristics before the officeholding rather than the effect of holding office itself.

I address this concern using two complementary comparison groups composed of families whose fathers were also politically active. The first design compares sons of officials who entered office in 1918 with sons of officials who entered shortly afterward in 1922. Because all fathers in this analysis eventually hold office, the groups are likely to be more similar in political ambition, engagement, and local standing than officials and non-officials in the baseline matched sample. The identifying variation comes from the narrow difference in timing that fathers entering in 1918 had already assumed office by the 1920 Census, whereas fathers entering in 1922 had not.

Figure 4 reports the result. There is no evidence of differential pre-treatment trends. By the 1920 Census, sons of officials who entered office in 1918 experience an increase in occupational income score relative to sons of officials who would enter office shortly thereafter. The pattern is consistent with the baseline estimates and suggests that the main findings are not driven solely by persistent differences between politically connected and nonpolitical families.

The second design compares the children of winning and losing candidates. Specifically, I compare the children of the last winner, i.e., the elected candidate receiving the fewest votes, to those of the first loser, i.e., the unelected candidate receiving the most votes, based on the vote returns.[15] Relative to the baseline matched design, this approach narrows the comparison to children whose fathers were actively competing for offices and are therefore likely to be more similar in unobserved ambition, political engagement, and local standing.

Figure 5 presents the corresponding event-study plot using a sample consisting of children of the last winning and first losing candidates. Although the estimates are less precise because of the small sample, the post-election pattern is again consistent with the baseline finding that sons of winning candidates tend to have higher occupational income

[15]The ideal design would be a regression discontinuity design. However, because election returns are available for only a limited sample of races recovered from historical newspapers, the sample is too small to implement an RDD.

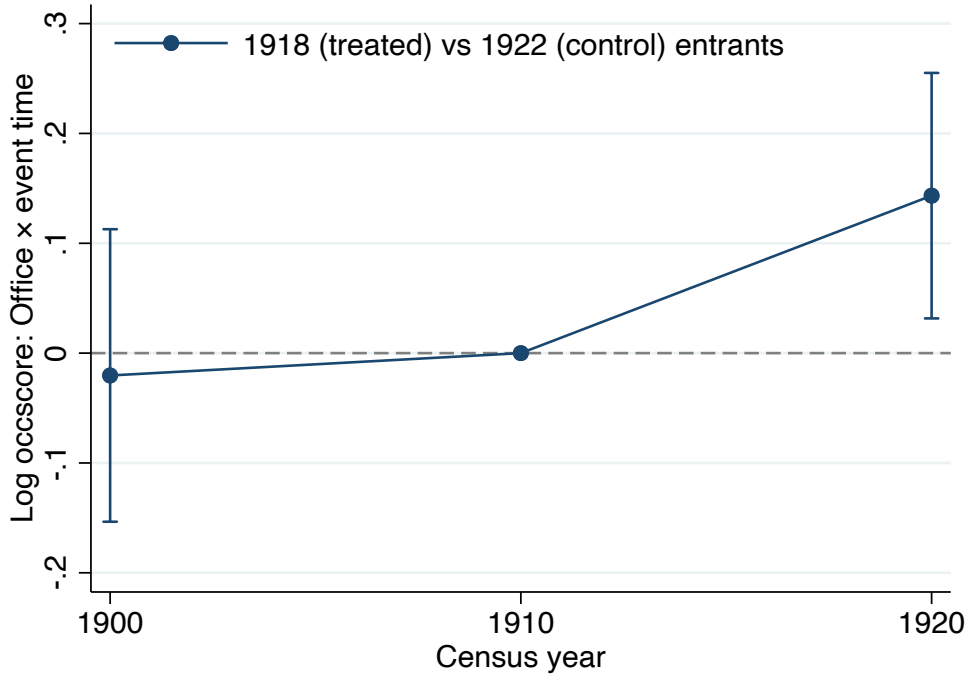


Figure 4. Comparing Children of Current Officials and Future Officials

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes sons whose fathers first enter local office in 1918 and sons whose fathers first enter office in 1922 from Census 1900 to 1920. Sons of 1918 entrants are the treated group, while sons of 1922 entrants are the future-treated comparison group. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

after fathers' office entry. Taken together, these two complementary designs provide support for the validity of the main results.[16]

Measurement error. The information on local officials is collected from *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers* between 1912 and 1929. I discuss some potential forms of measurement error that may arise from the construction of these data.

First, because the rosters collected start from 1912, a concern is that the recorded start year may not reflect the true beginning year of officials' officeholding, introducing measurement error in treatment timing. In the main analysis, I exclude officials who were first observed in 1912 to address the left-censoring problem. However, the concern still

[16]The estimates from the two complementary designs are somewhat larger in magnitude than the estimate from the main matched difference-in-differences design. The difference might reflect the differences in the sample of these designs. For the winners versus losers design, the sample includes mostly races for city mayors and councilmembers, which are usually positions with higher private returns than the others. The not-yet-treated design compares families that all eventually enter politics but differ in the timing of office entry, and therefore identifies effects within a more politically selected sample. Despite differences in magnitude, the estimates are consistently positive across designs.

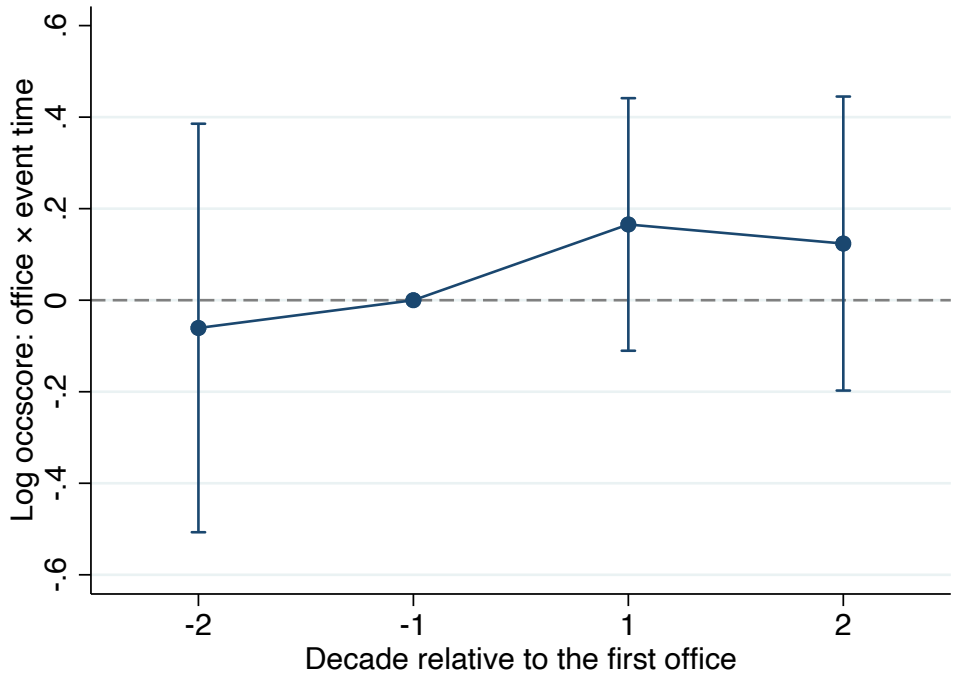


Figure 5. Comparing Children of Last Winning and First Losing Candidates

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes sons of last winning candidates and first losing candidates in races where information on electoral return is available. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

remains that some officials recorded as starting in 1914 or later may in fact have held office prior to 1912 or held the office in non-continuous years. To mitigate this possibility, I redo the analysis restricting the sample to individuals whose fathers are first observed entering office after 1920 and their matched controls, since it is less likely that officials had a gap of more than a decade in their political careers. Table D1 reports these results and gets similar effects of fathers' officeholding.

Second, reporting practices in the rosters vary across jurisdictions and years. In some years, some governments report only the president of the council while omitting the names of council members. This incomplete reporting may misclassify some officeholders as non-officeholders. If omitted officials enter the control group during matching, such misclassification would bias the estimated effects downward. Therefore, the estimates should be interpreted as lower bounds of the true effect of officeholding. To reduce this concern, the matching procedure described in Section 3.1 excludes individuals employed in the public sector in the Census from the pool of potential controls, since unreported local officials are more likely to appear in public-sector occupations.

Finally, errors may arise when linking officials in the rosters to individuals in the Census. The probability of incorrect links is higher when roster information is limited. In particular, some offices report only the initials of officials' first names rather than full names. To assess the sensitivity of the results to potential linking error, Table D4 therefore re-estimates the main specification after excluding officials whose first names are recorded only as initials. The estimates remain similar, while the white-collar estimate becomes less precise.

Census Linkage and Sample Composition. A separate concern arises when following officials' children and their matched counterparts across census waves. Because the construction of the sample relies on the CTP crosswalks to trace individuals over time, fathers' officeholding could affect sons' probability of being successfully linked in subsequent censuses. For example, if officeholding changes sons' geographic mobility or other characteristics related to historical record linkage, successful tracing could itself become an outcome of treatment and generate differential sample selection. I therefore estimate the event-study specification using an indicator for whether a son is successfully linked and residing in the state of Ohio, i.e., in the sample of the analysis. Figure D1 shows no evidence that fathers' officeholding affects sons' probability of being linked in the Ohio sample. As the main sample includes individuals who are linked to a given census and reside in the state of Ohio, the Ohio restriction could generate differential selection into the estimation sample if fathers' officeholding affects sons' interstate migration, for example, by making local opportunity more attractive or by facilitating opportunities elsewhere. Figure D2 examines this possibility and shows no evidence that fathers' officeholding differentially affects sons' probability of residing outside Ohio.

Even in the absence of selection in the sample by fathers' officeholding status, the baseline panel is unbalanced, so the set of individuals can vary across the event times. To assess whether changes in sample composition drive the results, I re-estimate the main specification using a fully balanced panel in which the same individuals are observed throughout the event window. Figure D3 shows that the estimates are almost unchanged in the fully balanced panel, confirming the result is not driven by compositional change of sample.

Reverse Causality. Another concern is that the estimated effect might reflect reverse causality that children's success may have helped their fathers obtain office, rather than officeholding improving children's subsequent outcomes. To test this possibility, I restrict the analysis to sons who were relatively young when their fathers entered office. These sons were less likely to possess the occupational standing, resources, or local influence

needed to affect their fathers' political careers. Table D2 still shows a positive effect of fathers' officeholding in this sample. The estimate is, if anything, larger among younger sons, which is inconsistent with the results being driven primarily by reverse causality from sons' prior success.

Spillovers from the officials. As discussed in Section 3.1, the matching compares children of officials with children of non-officials. Some comparison children may nevertheless belong to the extended families of local officials and may therefore benefit indirectly from political connections. Such spillovers might attenuate the effect of officeholding. I reconstruct the comparison group after excluding individuals who share a surname with any official in the same county. Table D3 reports estimates similar to the baseline results.

4.4 Robustness

In Appendix E.3, I show that the result is robust using alternative standard errors, fixed effects, measures of outcomes, specifications, and samples.

Alternative inference. Table E3 shows that the result is robust when the standard errors are clustered at the individual level, matched-pairs level, and county level.

Alternative fixed effects. Because the matching procedure pairs officials' sons with controls from the same pre-office county, treated and control individuals are exposed to similar local labor-market conditions prior to fathers' office entry. Table E4 further allows these local conditions to evolve flexibly over time. Column (2) replaces the separate county and census year fixed effects with pre-office-county-by-census-year fixed effects, thereby absorbing arbitrary census-year-specific shocks to each county. Column (3) instead includes matched-pair-by-census-year fixed effects, so that identification comes from comparisons between treated sons and their matched controls within the same matched set and Census year. The estimated effects remain similar in these alternative choices of fixed effects.

Alternative measures of outcomes and specifications. In Table E5 and Figure E9, I adopt different forms of the dependent variable (level, log, and LIDO score obtained from Saavedra and Twinam (2020) described in Section 2.2.6) and Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood estimation for the non-negative nature of the dependent variable (Silva and Tenreyro, 2006). All results show a positive effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' occupational income.

Alternative samples. Table E6 and Figure E10 show that the result is robust using a balanced panel, using only the sample of sons whose fathers started the office between 1914 and 1920 and their matched counterparts, and using only the sample of sons whose fathers started the office between 1920 and 1928 and their matched counterparts. Figure E11 shows that the result is robust to the exclusion of any county in Ohio.

Alternative set of local offices. The baseline definition of local officeholding includes all positions reported in the rosters, including both elected governing offices and appointed administrative or professional positions. To assess whether the results depend on this broad roster-based definition, I re-estimate the main specification restricting the sample to be sons of core elected offices, including city and village mayors, members of council, judges and township trustees, treasurers, clerks, and justices of peace. Table E7 shows a similar positive effects of fathers' officeholding on sons' occupational income.

5 How Does Officeholding Improve Occupational Outcomes?

This section explores how fathers' local officeholding improves sons' occupational outcomes. To clarify, because the analysis focuses on sons who were already of working age before their fathers entered office, changes in childhood investments or completed schooling are unlikely to explain the main results. I therefore focus on whether officeholding expands sons' access to employment opportunities.

Two channels are especially plausible. First, local officials may help their sons obtain public-sector jobs through appointment authority, recommendations, or other forms of political influence over hiring. Second, firms may offer better private-sector opportunities to officials' sons because employing politically connected employees can facilitate access to local governments or other resources. I use the term preferential access to encompass these forms of politically mediated advantage. In Section 5.4, I discuss some other potential explanations.

5.1 Preferential Access to Public Employment

Politicians often have discretion over hiring decisions in the public sector. Hence, public employment could often be allocated through patronage and political recommendations rather than exclusively through formal merit-based recruitment. This was especially

true in the United States before the widespread adoption of civil service reforms, when American politics operated largely under a patronage system (Wilson, 1961). Politicians could allocate government positions based on personal loyalty or family ties rather than merit. If local officials could influence hiring in the public sector, their children might gain preferential access to public-sector jobs, which may operate through channels such as direct appointment and political recommendations.

I begin by examining whether fathers' officeholding increases sons' probability of being employed in the public sector. Column (1) in Table 4 and Panel A in Figure 6 show a sizable and statistically significant increase in the probability that sons work in the public sector after fathers enter office. On average, fathers' entry into office increases their sons' probability of being employed in the public sector by 1.2 percentage points, roughly 70% of the control mean. This increase appears in the first census after fathers enter office and persists in subsequent censuses, showing that public-sector employment is an important margin through which the labor-market effects of officeholding arise.

Where within the public sector these gains occur points to a role for local political influence. If fathers' officeholding facilitated access to government jobs, the gains should be concentrated in positions in which local appointment authority or political recommendation networks matter more. Columns (2) to (5) in Table 4 disaggregate public employment by government type. The increase in sons' public-sector employment is concentrated in local government and the postal service, while there is no corresponding increase in state or federal employment, which lies largely outside local discretion.[17] This pattern is consistent with preferential access operating through local hiring discretion and political recommendation networks, rather than a general increase in sons' government employment.

The pattern across local government settings reinforces this interpretation. During the Progressive Era, many Ohio cities adopted civil service systems aimed at curbing patronage and formalizing recruitment. In contrast, villages and townships typically operated under weaker or non civil service mandates, granting local officials substantially greater discretion over public-sector hiring (Ohio Constitution, 1912). Consistent with this institutional distinction, Columns (1) to (3) in Table 5 show that fathers' officeholding

[17] One may wonder why local officeholding increases sons' employment in the postal service, given that postal jobs were federally administered and the Pendleton Act in 1883 curtailed patronage in part of the federal bureaucracy. Although local officials did not control federal hiring, postal employment remained tied to political recommendation networks (Johnson and Libecap, 1994). In addition, the federal civil service reform was gradual and incomplete, starting with larger offices and more urban offices, which left smaller local offices less impacted (Aneja and Xu, 2024).

significantly increases sons' public-sector employment for officials in village and township governments, while the effect for sons of officials in city governments' employment is much smaller and noisier. The larger gains in township and village governments are consistent with political connection being more valuable where local discretion over public employment is larger. As cities, villages, and townships might differ along other dimensions other than the hiring institutions, Section 6 further examines whether the returns to officeholding vary with civil-service status within city governments.

This public-sector employment advantage is concentrated among sons who were less occupationally advantaged before their fathers entered office. Columns (4) and (5) in Table 5 split the sample by sons' pre-office occupational income and show that the increase in public-sector employment is substantially larger for sons with lower pre-office occupational income relative to the public-sector mean. This finding suggests that officeholding did not simply affect the careers of sons who were already well positioned for relatively high-paying employment. Instead, the public-sector channel appears particularly important for sons for whom entry into these jobs represented a larger improvement over their pre-office occupational position.

Table 4. Impact on Public-Sector Employment

	Aggregate	Category			
	(1) Public sector	(2) Postal service	(3) Local government	(4) State government	(5) Federal government
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0115***	0.0067***	0.0041***	0.0003	0.0008
	(0.0022)	(0.0014)	(0.0015)	(0.0003)	(0.0007)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.0173	0.0068	0.0081	0.0003	0.0020
R^2	0.5083	0.5767	0.4149	0.3043	0.3641
Observations	88251	88251	88251	88251	88251

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of being employed in the public sector. The dependent variable for Column (1) is a dummy equal to one if the individual is employed in the public sector and zero otherwise. Columns (2) to (5) disaggregate the public sector into four categories: postal service (Column (2)), local governments (Column (3)), State government (Column (4)), and Federal government (Column (5)). The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

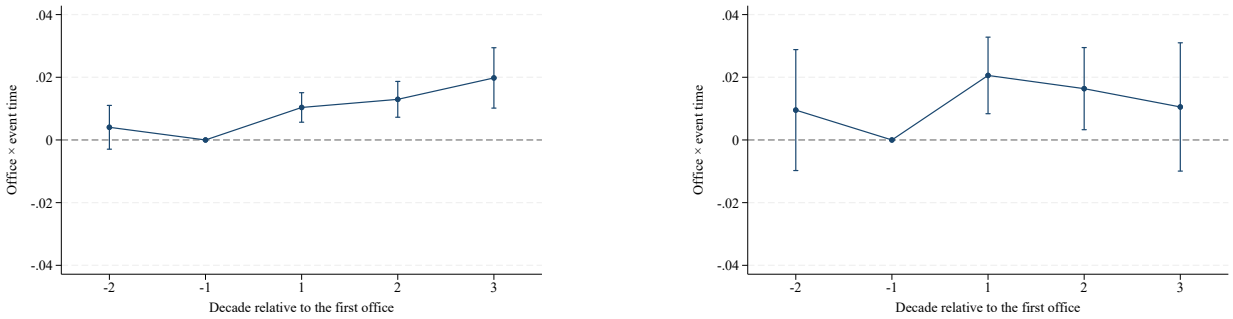
Table 5. Heterogeneity in Public-Sector Employment

	Dependent variable: Public-sector employment				
	Government Format			Pre-office Occscore	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	City	Village	Township	Low income	High income
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0029	0.0095***	0.0141***	0.0126***	0.0070
	(0.0092)	(0.0036)	(0.0029)	(0.0023)	(0.0066)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.0220	0.0196	0.0156	0.0140	0.0362
R^2	0.5135	0.5186	0.5036	0.4855	0.5525
Observations	5684	31900	50667	70387	14377

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of being employed in the public sector across different samples. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in the public sector and zero otherwise. Columns (1) to (3) separate the sample by the format of governments: city governments, village governments, and township governments. Columns (4) and (5) separate the sample by sons' occupational income at $t = -1$. Specifically, the sample in Column (4) includes sons with occupational income lower than the mean occupational income earned in the public sector and their matched counterparts while the sample in Column (5) includes son with higher occupational income than the average public sector occupational income and their matched counterparts. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

The data do not allow me to distinguish the specific ways in which fathers' officeholding facilitated sons' access to public employment, such as through direct appointments, political recommendations, or other forms of influence over hiring. However, historical accounts illustrate how such preferential access to public employment could operate in practice. Figure A5 and A6 present one example from Ohio, where a newspaper reports that the mayor of Dayton appointed his son as chief clerk, replacing the incumbent employee. While such examples do not establish how widespread direct appointments were, they illustrate one mechanism through which local political office could translate into public-sector employment opportunities for officials' sons.

Other mechanisms, such as changes in sons' preferences for government work, role-model effects, or improved information about public-sector opportunities, may also have contributed to the increase in public employment for officials' sons. I cannot rule out



A. Government Jobs

B. Private-sector White-collar Jobs

Figure 6. Dynamic Effects of Fathers' Officeholding on Jobs

Note: This figure reports event-study estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' employment outcomes from Equation 2 Panel A examines employment in the public sector, and Panel B examines employment in a white-collar job in the private sector. The solid dots report point estimates, and the bars show 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

these alternative explanations. Nevertheless, the concentration of the public employment increase in jobs and settings where local political influence could plausibly matter is consistent with preferential access to public-sector employment for officials' sons.

5.2 Better Opportunities in the Private Sector

Fathers' officeholding may also improve sons' opportunities outside the public sector. Local governments interact with firms through licensing, zoning, procurement, taxation, and other administrative decisions. These interactions may make politically connected workers valuable to private employers, whether because they facilitate access to officials, provide information about local government, or signal useful political relationships. This section examines whether fathers' officeholding increases sons' access to private-sector white-collar employment.

Column (1) of Table 6 and Panel B of Figure 6 show that sons of officials are more likely to be employed in private-sector white-collar jobs after their fathers take office, indicating that the occupational benefits of officeholding are not confined to government jobs.

The increase in private-sector white-collar employment is more concentrated in more urban settings. Columns (2) to (4) examine how the effect varies across government formats. The increase in private-sector white-collar employment is largest for sons of officials in city governments, smaller in village governments, and statistically indistinguishable from zero in township governments. Cities offered substantially more private-sector white-collar opportunities than smaller localities, providing greater scope for these employment gains.

Figure 7 further disaggregates private-sector white-collar employment by industry. The increase is concentrated in wholesale and retail trade and in finance, insurance, and real estate. These sectors are potentially sensitive to municipal regulation such as licensing and zoning, property decisions, and access to local information. The concentration of the effects in these industries provides suggestive evidence that firms might place value on workers connected to local political authority.

Taken together, the results show that private-sector white-collar employment is an additional margin through which fathers' officeholding benefits sons. The evidence is consistent with political connections improving sons' access to sectors in which relationships with local government are especially valuable. However, it is hard to distinguish whether these gains arise from employer demand for politically connected workers, referrals and recommendations by officials, or broader political and social networks. I therefore interpret the findings as evidence consistent with generally politically mediated access to private-sector opportunities.

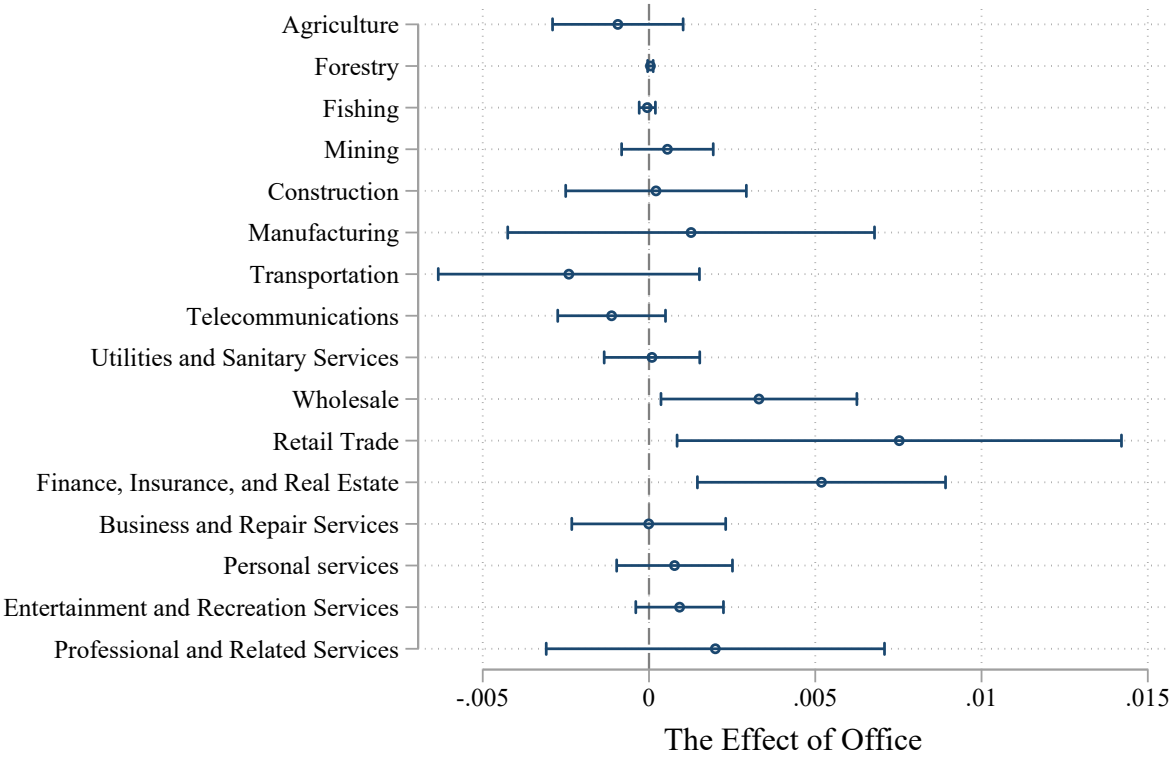


Figure 7. Heterogeneity in Private-sector White-collar Employment

Note: This figure plots the coefficient of Office × Post on the probability of being employed in white-collar jobs in the private sector by industries. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Table 6. Impact on Private-Sector White-collar Employment

	Aggregate	Government Format		
	(1) Private sector	(2) City	(3) Village	(4) Township
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0159***	0.0581**	0.0225**	0.0054
	(0.0054)	(0.0249)	(0.0094)	(0.0065)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.1887	0.3745	0.2375	0.1429
R^2	0.6361	0.6167	0.6312	0.6269
Observations	88251	5684	31900	50667

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on the probability of being employed in a white-collar job in the private sector. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in a white-collar job in the private sector and zero otherwise. Column (1) includes the full sample of matched sons who had reached working age in the pre-office census in Censuses 1900 to 1940. Columns (2) to (4) separate the sample by the format of governments: city governments, village governments, and township governments. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

5.3 Heterogeneity by Officials' Office

I explore the heterogeneity in the intergenerational political advantage by the type of government and political position held by the father in Appendix Section F.

I first examine whether the returns to fathers' officeholding vary across forms of local governments. Figure F1 shows that fathers' officeholding increases adult sons' occupational income for officials in all city, village, and township governments. In particular, the positive estimate for township officials suggests that the intergenerational political advantage extends well down the political hierarchy to township governments. Panel B and C further shows that the channels through which officeholding benefits sons differ with the scale and institutional environment of local government. In cities, where there are more economic opportunities and meanwhile more formal constraints on

public-sector hiring, the intergenerational political advantage is more associated with private-sector white-collar opportunities, whereas in smaller local governments, especially townships, public-sector employment is a more important margin of advantage.

Figure F2 further examines whether the intergenerational returns to fathers' officeholding vary across broad categories of local positions. Panel A shows that the largest increase in occupational income score is observed for sons of mayors and presidents of council, while the effect is much smaller for sons of trustees and clerks. Therefore, although the broader results show that political advantage could extend to relatively modest local offices, the magnitude of these returns could still vary with the prominence of the positions held by officials. Panel B and C further show that the composition of these gains differs across offices. Public-sector employment gains are particularly pronounced for sons of heads of police and fire, while private-sector white-collar employment gains are larger for sons of mayors and council presidents. These results suggest that both the magnitude and the channel of intergenerational political advantage vary across local political positions.

5.4 Other Mechanisms

This section examines alternative mechanisms through which fathers' officeholding increases sons' occupational income.

One potential explanation is occupational inheritance, whereby sons take over their fathers' pre-office jobs after fathers' office entry. This channel is unlikely for two reasons. First, many local offices during this period were not full-time positions and did not require officials to leave their previous employment (Ohio, 1910). Second, Table G1 directly tests whether sons are more likely to work in their fathers' pre-office occupations and shows no evidence consistent with this mechanism.

Another possibility is social-network expansion. Fathers' officeholding may broaden families' access to social and professional networks, which could indirectly improve sons' labor market prospects. While social networks are difficult to measure, Table G2 partially explores this channel by examining whether fathers' officeholding affects sons' marriage networks. Table G2 shows no evidence that sons of officials are more likely to marry spouses from wealthier families, from families with fathers employed in the public sector, or from families in white-collar occupations. These results suggest limited scope for marriage-based network expansion as a driver of the observed occupational gains.

Finally, the observed advantage could reflect a reputational effect, whereby sons benefit from the prestige or visibility associated with their fathers' political status. If reputation operates primarily through name recognition, its effects should be stronger for sons with less common surnames, whose family identity is more easily identifiable. Table G3 tests this implication and finds no significant heterogeneity by surname commonness for sons' occupational income score. There is some suggestive evidence that officials' sons with rare surnames have a higher probability of being employed in private-sector white-collar jobs.

6 Civil Service Reform and the Returns to Local Officeholding

The previous section shows that fathers' officeholding improves their adult sons' occupational income, and access to public employment is an important margin through which fathers' officeholding benefits their sons, particularly in settings where local officials have greater scope to influence hiring. This raises a natural question: how do formal institutions restricting discretion in public-sector hiring affect the intergenerational advantages of local officeholding? I examine this question using the staggered adoption of municipal civil-service systems across Ohio cities described in Section 2.1.2.

I compare fathers who first enter office before versus after their city has established a civil-service system. I classify fathers based on the hiring institutions in place when they first enter office, and this classification remains fixed over time. Thus, fathers who enter before reform remain in the pre-reform group even if their city adopts civil service later. The estimates therefore capture how the returns to officeholding differ depending on the institutional environment at entry, rather than the effect of whether civil service is in place in each later census year. Specifically, I estimate a triple-differences specification that interacts fathers' officeholding, post-office dummy, and whether the city had already adopted civil service when the father first entered office. The coefficient on the triple interaction captures how the effect of fathers' officeholding differs when fathers enter office under a civil-service system. Civil service adoption was not random. Larger cities, cities with home rule, and cities with at-large councils tended to adopt civil service earlier (Kuipers and Sahn, 2023; Ruhil, 2003). I therefore interpret the analysis as comparing the returns to local officeholding across different hiring regimes rather than as estimating the

causal effect of civil-service adoption itself. The estimation specification is as follows:

$$y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + \beta_1 \text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it} + \beta_2 \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it} + \beta_3 \text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it} + \beta_4 \text{Post}_{it} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \tag{3}$$

where $\text{Reform}_{j(i)}$ is a binary variable equal to one if the city in which father j holds office had already adopted a civil-service system at the time of his office entry, and zero otherwise. Reform status is therefore fixed for each treated father and is assigned to the matched control. Because civil service reforms were more likely to be adopted earlier in larger cities, where labor market conditions may differ systematically, I additionally control for interactions between city population size, measured by population in the 1930 Census, and $\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$. The population is recentered at its sample mean, so the $\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$ coefficient corresponds to the pre-reform effect for an average-sized city.

Table 7 reports the results. Columns (1) and (2) examine sons' occupational income. The estimated effect of fathers' officeholding is about 8 percent when fathers enter office before civil-service adoption and about 3 percent when they enter under civil service. The triple-difference estimate is negative, but imprecisely estimated and statistically insignificant.

The public-sector employment exhibit the expected pattern that the adoption of civil service systems could attenuate officials' advantage in public-sector hiring. Fathers' officeholding increases sons' public employment by about 2.6 percentage points when fathers enter office before civil-service adoption, whereas the estimated effect is approximately zero when fathers enter office under civil service. The triple-difference estimate is negative, as predicted, but is not statistically significant.

The clearest difference across civil-service regimes appears in private-sector white-collar employment. There is no positive effect of fathers' officeholding among officials entering office before civil-service adoption. In contrast, when fathers enter office under civil service, officeholding increases sons' private-sector white-collar employment by about 6.7 percentage points. The triple-difference estimate is approximately 16 percentage points and statistically significant, indicating that the effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' private-sector white-collar employment is significantly larger when fathers enter office under civil service.

Taken together, these results provide limited evidence that civil service systems reduce intergenerational political advantages. While the adoption of the civil service systems

Table 7. Impact by Civil Service Reform Status

	Logged Income Score$_{it}$		Government Job$_{it}$		Private White-collar$_{it}$	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Reform$_{j(i)}$ × Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	-0.049	-0.048	-0.027	-0.028	0.161**	0.163**
	(0.065)	(0.065)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.076)	(0.076)
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.082	0.081	0.024	0.026	-0.094	-0.097
	(0.062)	(0.062)	(0.024)	(0.025)	(0.070)	(0.070)
Population$_{j(i)}$ × Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$		-0.001		0.001		-0.003**
		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)
Office × Post (Pre-reform)	0.082	0.081	0.024	0.026	-0.094	-0.097
	(0.062)	(0.062)	(0.024)	(0.025)	(0.070)	(0.070)
Office × Post (Post-reform)	0.033	0.033	-0.003	-0.002	0.067**	0.066**
	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.028)	(0.027)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	29.652	29.652	0.025	0.025	0.398	0.398
R^2	0.711	0.711	0.528	0.529	0.668	0.669
Observations	4934	4934	5159	5159	5159	5159

Note: This table reports regression results of triple differences estimated using Equation 3. The dependent variables are log occupational income score (Columns (1)-(2)), whether employed in the public sector (Columns (3)-(4)), and whether employed in the private-sector white-collar jobs (Columns (5)-(6)). The sample includes sons of officials in the city governments and their matched counterparts. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Reform is a binary variable equal to 1 if individual's father starts the office when the city has already adopted the civil service reform and equal to 0 otherwise. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post$_{it}$ is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. *Population* is the log form of city's population in 1930 and is recentered by the mean. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

constrains the discretion over public-sector hiring, the reform could change the compositions of channels where political advantage is transmitted: for cities under civil service system, officials' sons are substantially more likely to be employed in the private-sector white-collar jobs, where hiring is not directly governed by civil service rules. The results therefore suggest that meritocratic reforms to public-sector hiring may constrain one avenue through which political connections operate without eliminating the broader labor-market advantages associated with those connections.

7 Exploring Potential Downstream Effects

So far, the paper documents that fathers' local officeholding increases sons' public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar employment. Beyond the officials' families, these gains may also have broader consequences for the allocation of economic opportunities within local communities. I focus the downstream analysis on the public employment channel because public-sector employment is an important margin of political advantage and meanwhile public-sector positions are relatively limited in number, making the local concentration of officials' sons a meaningful measure. Such consequences may be particularly relevant in small jurisdictions, where public-sector positions and other desirable jobs are relatively scarce. This section explores whether localities with greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit different patterns of income inequality.

The analysis in this section is exploratory. Officials' sons are not exogenously assigned to public-sector jobs or across localities, and their presence may be correlated with persistent political, institutional, or economic characteristics. The estimates should therefore be interpreted as suggestive rather than as causal effects of intergenerational political advantage.

Measuring Local Exposure. To measure locality-level exposure to intergenerational political advantage, I construct a proxy based on the share of public-sector employees residing in a locality who are sons of local officials, as observed in the 1930 Census. I identify individuals' residential localities in the Census using place linkages from Berkes et al. (2023). Note that this measure is based on the son's place of residence rather than the jurisdiction in which his father held office. I therefore do not require an official's son to reside in the same locality where his father served. This choice reflects limitations in consistently mapping locality names in the official rosters to Census place identifiers that locality names are not always recorded consistently across the two sources, making a systematic same-jurisdiction match difficult. The measure should therefore be interpreted as capturing the local concentration of individuals from politically connected families in public employment, rather than the share of public employees directly connected to officials serving in that particular locality. I focus on townships and cities. Matching villages across the rosters and Census place data is particularly difficult because village names are often shared with cities or townships within the same county. Requiring an unambiguous match between roster and Census locality names would leave only around 20 villages, which is too small for a meaningful locality-level analysis. I therefore exclude

villages from this exercise. For townships and cities, I further exclude places whose names overlap within the same county to reduce ambiguity in assigning Census observations to locality type. This procedure yields a matched sample of 967 townships and 60 cities.

In some townships, the number of public-sector employees observed in the Census is very small, causing the exposure share to take mechanically extreme values.[18] I therefore restrict the baseline analysis to localities with at least five observed public-sector employees. This makes the measure more interpretable as a feature of local public-sector composition rather than an artifact of a very small denominator. I also control for the public-employment share of the local population to account for differences in local government size. Appendix Section H shows consistent results when using the full sample and alternative thresholds for the number of public employees.

Figure A7 plots the distribution of the locality-level exposure measure, the share of public employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. In both types of localities, the distribution is highly concentrated near zero, indicating that officials' sons generally account for only a small fraction of the local public-sector workforce. The city distribution is particularly concentrated at very low values, while townships exhibit greater dispersion and a longer right tail. Overall, the figure shows that exposure is typically limited but varies more substantially across townships than across cities. In the analysis, I use both measures of (i) a binary indicator for whether a locality employs at least one official's son in the public sector and (ii) a continuous measure equal to the share of public employees who are sons of local officials.

Table 8 examines whether the local concentration of officials' sons in public employment is associated with broader differences in the distribution of income. The analysis is conditional on locality characteristics including the male, white, native-born, urban, employed, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, as well as log population. I also control for pre-existing inequality using the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Because individual wage income is not available in the 1930 Census, this measure is an occupation-based proxy for baseline inequality. The estimates therefore compare localities with similar observed demographic composition, economic structure, public-sector size, population, and initial inequality, rather than capturing unconditional differences across localities.

[18] For example, if only two public employees are observed, the presence of one official's son generates an exposure share of one-half.

Table 8. Exposure to Intergenerational Political Advantages and Subsequent Income Inequality.

	Township				City			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share
Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)	0.016***		0.013***		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.006)		(0.005)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.020***		0.020***		-0.007		0.004
		(0.007)		(0.006)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.578	0.578	0.343	0.343	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.658	0.658	0.609	0.612	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	469	469	469	469	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. The sample includes cities and townships with public employees size at least 5. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). *Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)* is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

Columns (1) – (4) report the results for townships. Greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment is associated with higher income inequality in 1940. A one-standard-deviation increase in their share among public employees is associated with a 0.016 increase in the Gini coefficient and a 1.3-percentage-point increase in the share of income accruing to the top decile. When exposure is measured using the binary indicator, the presence of at least one such employee is associated with an approximately 0.02 increase in the Gini coefficient and a 2.0-percentage-point increase in the top-decile income share. These relationships are estimated conditional on township demographic and economic characteristics and the corresponding Gini coefficient in 1930. The estimates therefore do not simply reflect persistent differences in pre-existing inequality or observable township composition. To provide a sense of magnitude, the estimate in Column (4) corresponds to a 2.0-percentage-point increase in the top-decile income share. Relative to the sample mean of 34.3 percent, this represents an increase of approximately 5.8 percent in earnings accruing to the top-decile.

Columns (5) – (8) report the corresponding estimates for cities. In contrast to the township results, neither the continuous exposure measure nor the binary measure for employing at least one official's son is significantly associated with the Gini coefficient or the top-decile income share. The point estimates are also small and close to zero.

Table H1 and Table H2 show a consistent result using the full sample and using samples of localities with at least ten public sector employees observed.

The township results provide suggestive evidence of a potential distributional cost of intergenerational political advantage. This pattern is particularly relevant for townships, where the individual-level results show that public-sector employment is an important margin of the intergenerational effects of officeholding. One possible interpretation is that advantages associated with political connections are more consequential in thinner labor markets, where public-sector and other higher-paying opportunities are relatively scarce. In such settings, a greater presence of politically connected workers in public employment may be associated with a more unequal allocation of economic opportunities. By contrast, in cities, larger and more diversified labor markets may make the presence of a relatively small number of such workers less consequential for the overall income distribution.

8 Concluding Remarks

This paper studies how local political power affects the economic opportunities of officials' children. I build a new dataset by digitizing records of township, village, and city officials in early twentieth-century Ohio and linking them to full-count U.S. censuses to follow their children over much of their working lives. Using a matched difference-in-differences design, I find that fathers' entry into local office improves sons' occupational outcomes, with these gains persisting for decades. The effects for daughters are considerably more limited in this context of low female labor force participation. Because the children in the analysis had already reached working age before their fathers entered office, these results show that changes in a parent's political position can alter the labor-market trajectories of adult children, rather than operating primarily through childhood investments in human capital.

The evidence points to access to employment as an important source of these gains. Fathers' officeholding increases sons' employment in the public sector, particularly in local government, and these gains are larger in villages and townships, where public-sector hiring was less constrained by formal civil-service rules. Political advantage also extends beyond government employment. Officials' sons are more likely to work in private-sector white-collar occupations, especially in cities and in sectors where relationships with local government are likely to be more valuable. The civil-service results further suggest that institutions governing public hiring shape how these advantages are transmitted. For officials starting officeholding in cities adopting the civil service system, the intergenerational political advantages shift to the private-sector white-collar jobs, where hiring is not directly regulated. Formal constraints on discretion can therefore limit an

important channel of political advantage without necessarily eliminating the advantages associated with political connections altogether.

These findings broaden the way we think about the private returns to political power. The officials studied here were not national politicians or entrenched political elites. Many held relatively modest local offices, especially in villages and townships, and came from occupational and family backgrounds close to the middle of the local distribution. Yet acquiring these offices generated long-run economic advantages for their adult children. Political power can therefore contribute to the intergenerational transmission of advantage not only through the persistence of political dynasties, but also by shaping who gains access to economic opportunities outside politics.

The exploratory locality-level evidence points to a possible broader consequence of this process. Townships with greater shares of officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit higher income inequality, whereas I find no comparable relationship in cities. These estimates are not causal, but the contrast is consistent with political connections being more consequential in thinner labor markets, where public-sector and other high-paying opportunities are relatively scarce. More generally, the results suggest that the distributional consequences of political connections may depend not only on whether preferential access exists, but also on the institutions and labor markets in which it operates.

I conclude this paper by noting several limitations. First, I focus on a historical setting in which labor markets and gender roles differed substantially from those today, and caution is therefore warranted in extrapolating the magnitudes to contemporary contexts. Second, the available data cannot fully distinguish among direct appointments, political recommendations, employer demand for connected workers, and other ways in which political connections facilitate access to employment. Third, the downstream analysis is descriptive and should therefore be interpreted as suggestive rather than causal. These limitations leave important questions for future work, including how intergenerational political advantage affects public-sector performance, firm behavior, and the allocation of economic resources.

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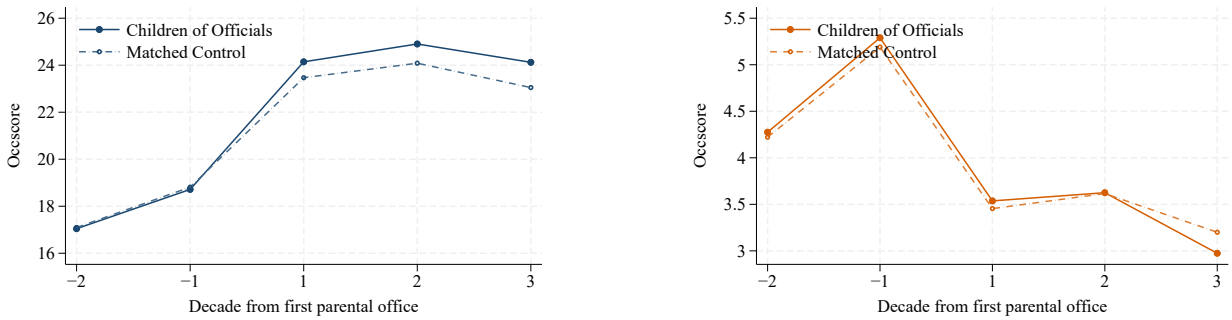
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A Additional Figures

Figure A1. Occupational Income Trends in the Matched Sample



A. Sons **B.** Daughters

Note: This figure plots the raw mean occupational income score (OCCSCORE) of officials' children and their matched controls by census wave relative to fathers' first entry into local office. Panel A reports the comparison for sons, and Panel B reports the comparison for daughters. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts.

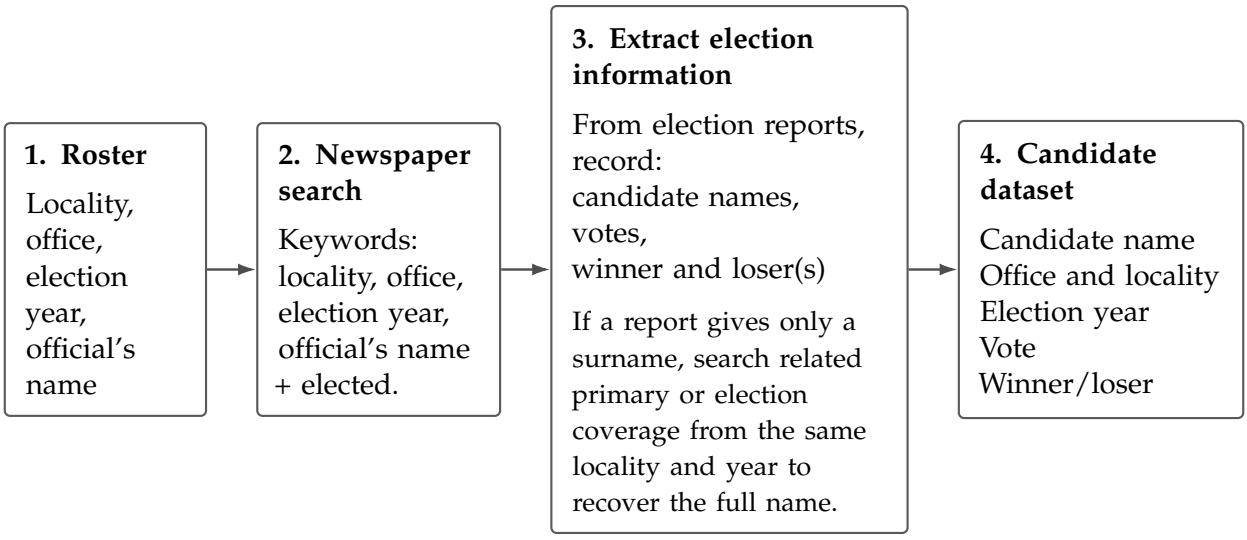
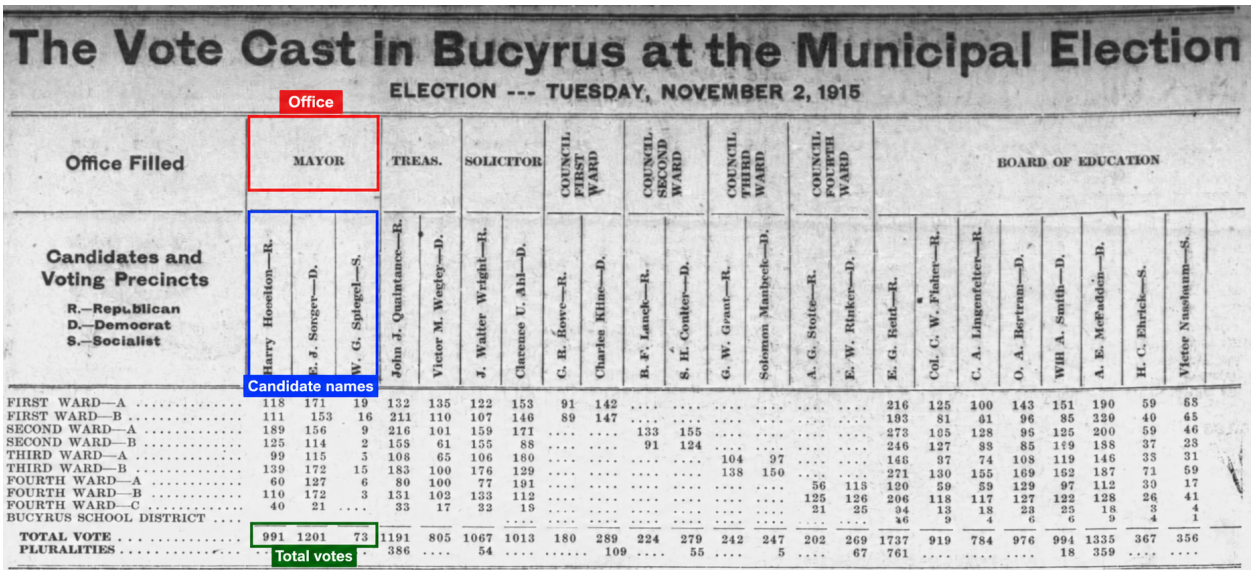


Figure A2. Collection of candidate names and electoral returns from historical newspapers.

For each office-year in the Ohio official rosters, I use the locality, office, election year, and winning official's name to search historical newspapers. Some newspapers report election results, providing candidates' names and electoral returns. When names are incomplete, I use related primary or election coverage from the same locality and year to recover the candidate's full name.



The Vote Cast in Bucyrus at the Municipal Election

ELECTION --- TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 1915

Office

Office Filled	MAYOR			TREAS.		SOLICITOR		COUNCIL FIRST WARD		COUNCIL SECOND WARD		COUNCIL THIRD WARD		COUNCIL FOURTH WARD		BOARD OF EDUCATION							
Candidates and Voting Precincts R.—Republican D.—Democrat S.—Socialist	Harry Hoselton—R.	E. J. Songer—D.	W. G. Spiegel—S.	John J. Quintance—R.	Victor M. Wegley—D.	J. Walter Wright—R.	Clarence U. Abl—D.	G. R. Rowe—R.	Charles Kline—D.	B. F. Lauck—R.	S. H. Coulter—D.	G. W. Grant—R.	Solomon Manbeck—D.	A. G. Stotte—R.	E. W. Rinker—D.	E. G. Reid—R.	Col. C. W. Fisher—R.	C. A. Lingenfelter—R.	O. A. Bertram—D.	Will A. Smith—D.	A. E. McFadden—D.	H. C. Ehrick—S.	Victor Nusbaum—S.
FIRST WARD—A	118	171	19	132	135	122	153	91	142	....	....	....	....	....	....	216	125	100	143	151	190	59	68
FIRST WARD—B	111	153	16	211	110	107	146	89	147	....	....	....	....	....	....	193	81	91	96	85	220	40	65
SECOND WARD—A	189	156	9	216	101	159	171	....	....	133	155	....	....	....	....	273	105	128	95	125	200	59	46
SECOND WARD—B	125	114	2	155	61	155	88	....	....	91	124	....	....	....	....	246	127	93	85	119	188	37	23
THIRD WARD—A	99	115	5	108	65	106	180	....	....	....	....	104	97	....	....	146	97	74	108	119	146	33	31
THIRD WARD—B	139	172	15	183	100	176	129	....	....	....	....	138	150	....	....	271	130	155	169	162	187	71	59
FOURTH WARD—A	60	127	6	80	100	77	191	....	....	....	....	....	....	56	115	120	59	59	129	97	112	39	17
FOURTH WARD—B	110	172	3	151	102	133	112	....	....	....	....	....	....	125	126	206	118	117	127	122	128	26	41
FOURTH WARD—C	40	21	....	33	17	32	19	....	....	....	....	....	....	21	25	94	13	18	23	25	18	3	4
BUCYRUS SCHOOL DISTRICT																46	9	4	6	6	9	4	1
TOTAL VOTE	991	1201	73	1191	805	1067	1013	180	289	224	279	242	247	202	269	1737	919	784	976	994	1335	367	356
PLURALITIES				386	....	54	....	....	109	....	55	....	5	....	67	761	....	....	....	18	359	....	....

Candidate names

Total votes

Figure A3. Example: Newspaper Coverage on Election

Note: This figure presents an example of historical newspaper coverage used to collect local election returns. The newspaper reports candidates' last names, offices, and vote totals, which I use to identify both winning and losing candidates for the electoral comparison. Source: The Bucyrus Evening Telegraph, November 3, 1915, Page 6, accessed via Newspapers.com.

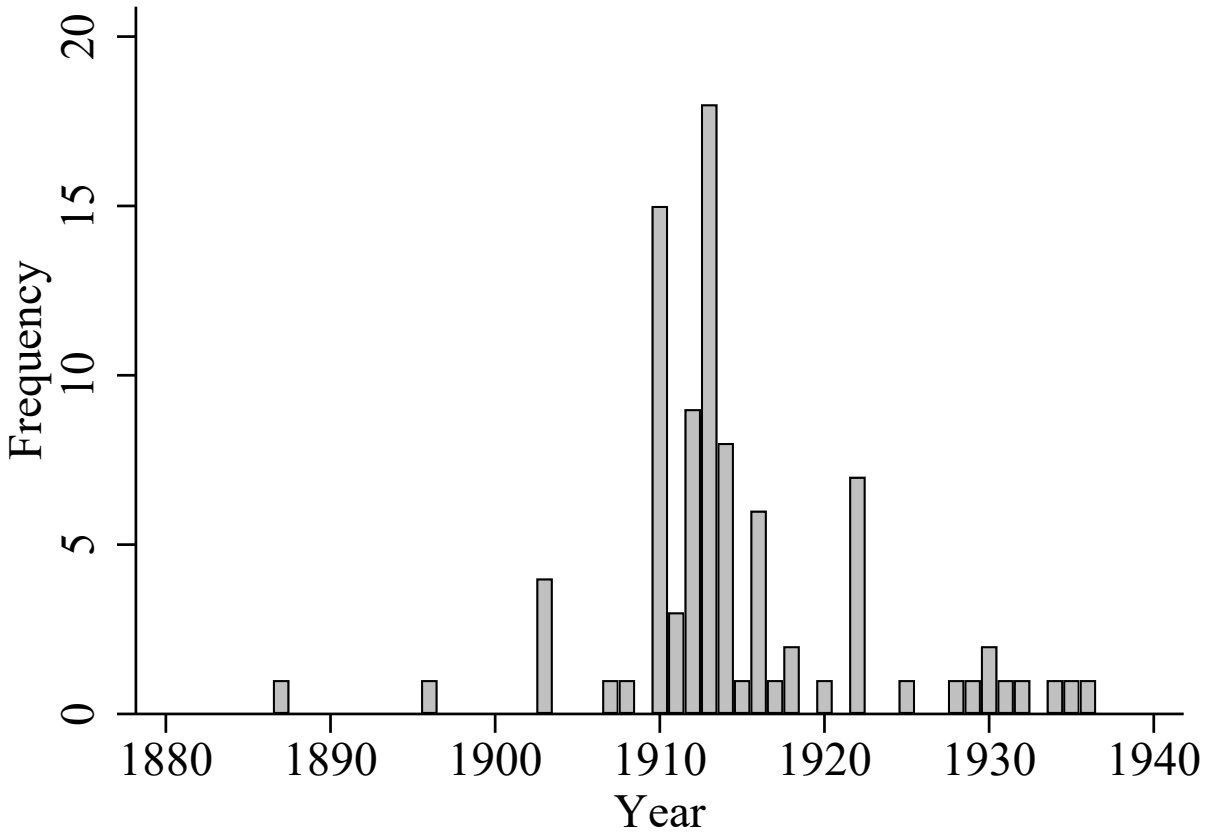
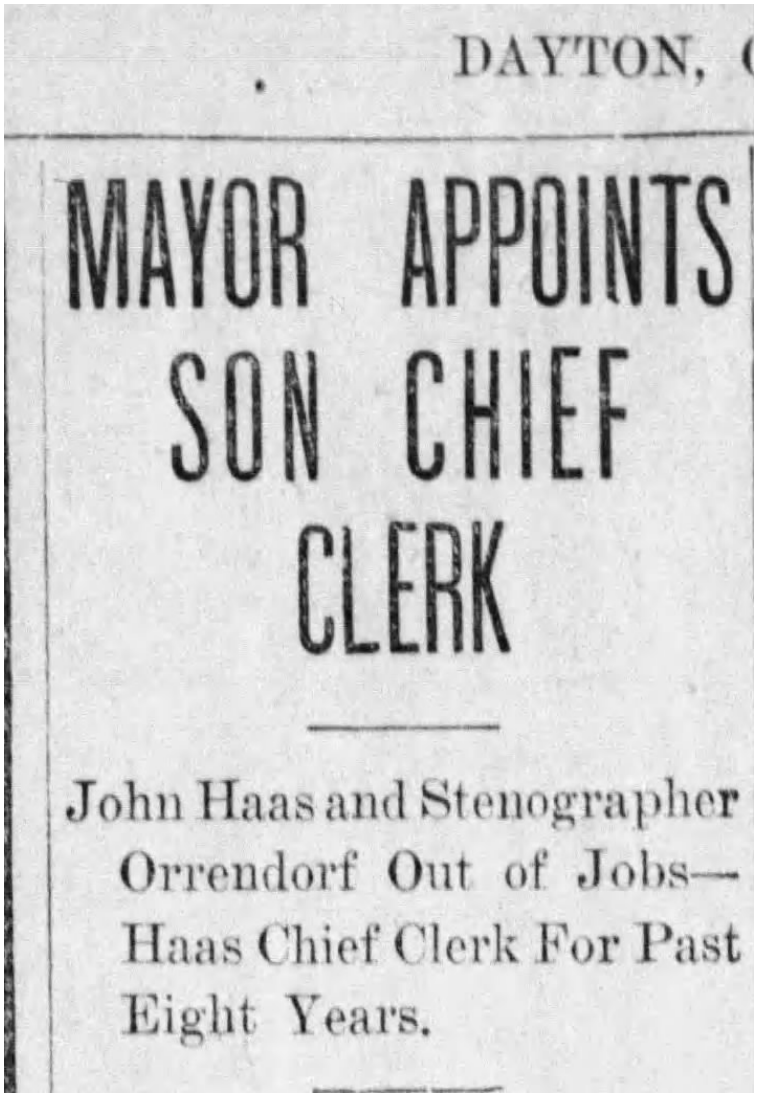


Figure A4. Adoption of Civil Service Reform in Ohio Municipalities

Note: This figure plots the distribution of civil-service reform adoption years across Ohio municipalities. Each bar reports the number of municipalities (including both cities and villages) adopting a civil-service system in the corresponding year. Reform timing is obtained from Kuipers and Sahn (2023).



DAYTON, (

MAYOR APPOINTS SON CHIEF CLERK

John Haas and Stenographer Orrendorf Out of Jobs—Haas Chief Clerk For Past Eight Years.

Figure A5. Clipping from *The Dayton Herald*, October 30, 1906, p. 9, via Newspapers.com

WILL REMAIN IN OFFICE A MONTH

Mayor Calvin D. Wright late Monday afternoon appointed as his chief clerk, his son, William B. Wright, to succeed John A. Haas. E. L. Orrendorf, Mayor Snyder's stenographer, has been notified that his services will no longer be needed. He will leave the employ of the city Wednesday.

The chief clerkship pays $1,500, while the stenographer gets $900. John Haas has been in the Mayor's office since 1898, having served under Mayor Lindemuth and Mayor Snyder. John is widely known in the city, and it is with extreme regret that his friends see him leave public office. His jovial disposition and pleasant ways have made him a favorite in the City Hall, and Republicans and Democrats alike, regret to see him go.

The new clerk, William B. Wright, is 32 years old and lives on Maple street. He has been connected with the National Cash Register Company for seven years, where he worked himself up to a responsible position in the treasurer's office. He is well fitted for the position he will assume.

Mr. Haas will probably remain in the office for a month until the new clerk becomes familiar with the duties.

Figure A6. Clipping from *The Dayton Herald*, October 30, 1906, p. 9, via Newspapers.com

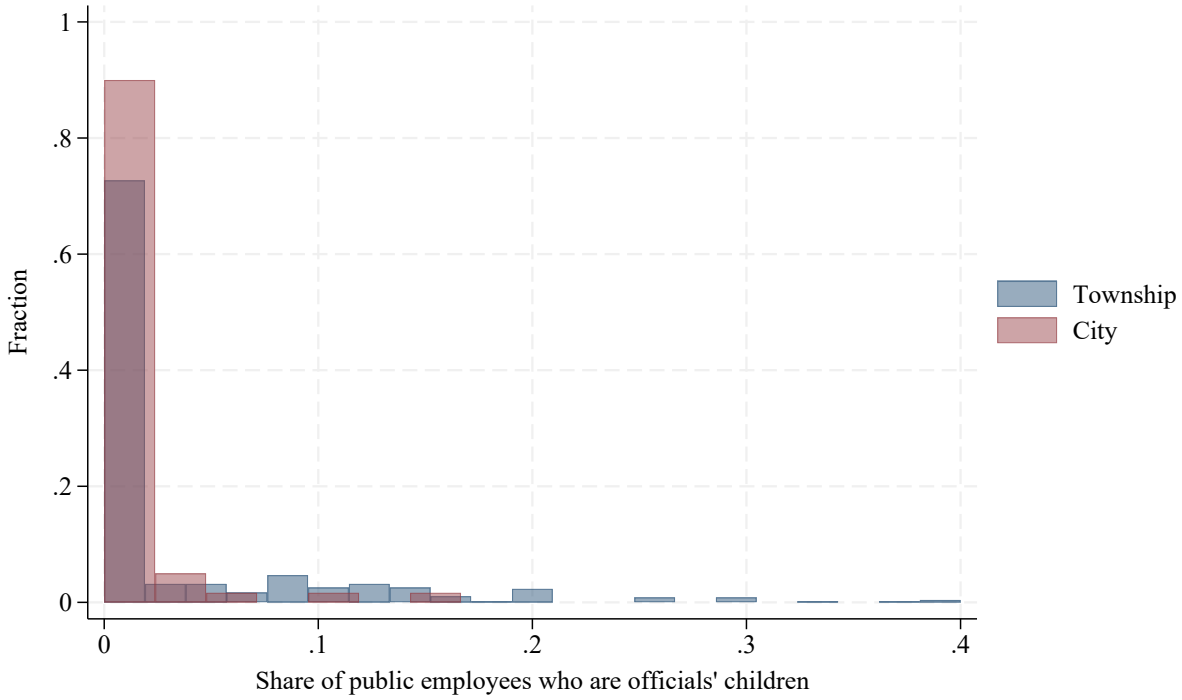


Figure A7. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample is restricted to localities with at least five public-sector employees observed in the 1930 Census.

B Additional Table

Table B1. List of Offices by Forms of Government

Government Form	Offices
Township	Clerk; Treasurer; Trustee; Justice of the Peace
Village	Assessor; Board of Education; Board of Public Affairs; Clerk; Commissioner; Health Officer; Manager; Marshal; Mayor; Members of Council; Solicitor; Street Commissioner; Treasurer
City	Assessors; Assistants; Auditor and Treasurer; Bailiff; Boards of Health, Education, Library, or Review; Chemist at Water Plant; Chief Justice; Chief of Police/Fire; City Attorney; City Engineer; City Manager; Civil Service Commission; Clerk; Commissioners of Accounts, Public Buildings, Treasury, Water; Directors of Finance, Law, and Public Services/Safety/Health; Judges; Mayor; Members of Council; Members of City Commission; Municipal Court; Members of Planning, Playground, Smoke Abatement, Sinking Fund, and Tax Commissions; Police Justice; Sanitary Officer; Solicitor; Superintendent; Vice Mayor; Vice President of Council

Note: This table presents the lists of offices reported in the rosters.

Table B2. Linking Roster to Census: Linking rate

	All		*City*		*Village*		*Township*	
	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total
All	0.70	179952	0.72	21007	0.66	82559	0.73	76386
1912-1913	0.70	20866	0.71	2402	0.67	9266	0.73	9198
1914-1915	0.70	19398	0.72	1924	0.67	8396	0.73	9078
1916-1917	0.71	18432	0.74	1825	0.66	7570	0.74	9037
1918-1919	0.71	19735	0.74	2046	0.67	8673	0.75	9016
1920-1921	0.73	19385	0.73	1879	0.71	8800	0.75	8706
1922-1923	0.71	19880	0.72	2420	0.68	8681	0.75	8779
1924-1925	0.69	18754	0.72	2514	0.66	8767	0.71	7473
1926-1927	0.68	20627	0.70	2552	0.65	10600	0.72	7475
1928-1929	0.67	22875	0.70	3445	0.63	11806	0.71	7624

Note: This table presents the link rates of linking roster data to full-count individual censuses.

Table B3. Baseline Characteristics

	All	*City*	*Village*	*Township*
	Mean	Mean	Mean	Mean
Panel A: Local officials				
Male	0.936	0.926	0.925	0.950
White	0.985	0.984	0.982	0.988
Age first in office	46.702	46.937	45.792	47.597
Foreign born	0.034	0.055	0.036	0.025
Immigrant parents	0.213	0.290	0.212	0.193
Literate	0.984	0.986	0.981	0.987
Pre-office occscore	21.569	31.757	23.664	16.507
Pre-office public sector	0.022	0.069	0.021	0.010
Obs	57,936	6,634	26,288	25,014
Panel B: Population (Census 1920)				
Male	0.513	0.511	0.493	0.524
White	0.967	0.957	0.978	0.987
Age	29.224	28.418	31.686	28.927
Foreign born	0.119	0.194	0.050	0.051
Immigrant parents	0.332	0.488	0.187	0.177
Literate	0.971	0.963	0.980	0.976
Occscore	13.803	15.820	13.555	9.384
Public sector	0.007	0.010	0.007	0.003
Obs	5,763,198	1,764,029	505,897	1,452,462

Note: Panel A reports characteristics of local officials linked to the Census, and Panel B reports corresponding characteristics of the Ohio population in the 1920 Census. For officials' pre-office occupational income score, individuals first observed in office in 1912–1913 are excluded because they may already have held office by the 1910 Census, so the 1910 observation cannot be reliably treated as pre-office. In Panel B, occupational income scores are calculated for individuals ages 25–65.

C Local Officials in Ohio

C.1 Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers

AKRON—POPULATION, 69,000.

Office.	Name of Officer.	Politics.	Term Expires.
Mayor	Isaac Myers	D	Jan. 1, 1920
President of Council	Jesse Merriman	R	Jan. 1, 1920
Auditor	Thomas Heffernan	D	Jan. 1, 1920
Treasurer	Wm. Hoover	D	Jan. 1, 1920
Solicitor	Scott D. Kenfield	R	Jan. 1, 1920
Police or Municipal Judge	John R. Vaughan	D	Jan. 1, 1919
Director of Public Service	Carl F. Beck	R	Jan. 10, 1918
Director of Public Safety	Charles R. Morgan	R	Jan. 10, 1918
Trustees of Sinking Fund and Board of Tax Commissioners	Joseph Winum	D	
	Armar Carnaham	R	
	P. Tobrie	D	
	W. H. Means	R	
Board of Healt	George Kuhlke	D	
	A. B. Jones	R	
	Charles Hoffman	....	
	Dr. Armin Sicherman	....	
	Dr. Van der Hulse	....	
Board of Library Trustee	Harry L. Snyder	R	
	Jesse P. Dice	R	
	Hugh Allen	R	
	A. Holm	D	
	John Gross	D	
Board of Education	H. T. Waller	R	
	Mrs. A. Ross Read	....	
	J. Asa Palmer	D	
	D. W. Kaufman	R	
	C. W. Berry	R	
	C. M. Woodruff	R	
Chief of Police	John Durkin	D	Civil Service.
Chief of Fire Department	John T. Merty	R	Civil Service.
City Engineer	Earl Zeisloft	R	Civil Service.

Figure C1. Example page for city officials

ADAMS COUNTY.

Village.	Population.	Office.	Names.	Politics.	Term Expires.
Manchester	2,000	Mayor	A. H. Holderness	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Clerk	S. N. Greenle	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Treasurer	Guy Ellison	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Marshal	Richard Harris	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Members of Council	G. E. Neal	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Robert Poole	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Dan Grimsby	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			John Bell	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Samuel Batharlomew	....	Dec. 31, 1919
		Board of Public Affairs	Ed. Smelling	....	
			Rufus McCormick	....	
			D. J. Slableton	....	
		Board of Education	John Koeple	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			J. C. Henderson	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			P. D. Vance	....	Dec. 31, 1921
			R. E. Shelton	....	Dec. 31, 1921
			Rufus Cox	....	Dec. 31, 1921
Peebles		Mayor	J. N. Askren	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Clerk	H. B. Hunter	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Treasurer	G. E. Henty	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Marshal	Geo. Hoop	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Members of Council	W. A. Thompson	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. C. Condon	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			E. W. Thomas	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			Harry Parker	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			Jacob Custer	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			M. T. Newman	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Board of Education	C. A. Watts	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			D. W. Reynolds	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			P. A. Campbell	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			D. W. Shoemaker	....	Jan. 1, 1922
			E E. Mathias	....	Jan. 1, 1922
Seaman	600	Mayor	J. T. Ryan	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Clerk	Homer King	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Treasurer	F. G. Young	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Marshal	John Hannah	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Members of Council	C. E. Haas	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. E. Sturn	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. E. Heidrick	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			J. A. Caskey	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. W. Elmore	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. S. Moore	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Board of Education	J. O. Kendall	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			H. A. Grooms	D	Jan. 1, 1922
			E. C. Zimmerman	R	Jan. 1, 1922

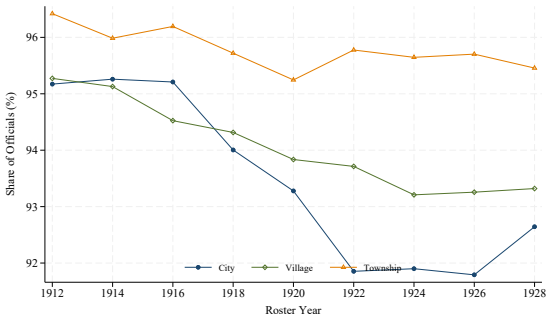
Figure C2. Example page for village officials

ADAMS COUNTY.

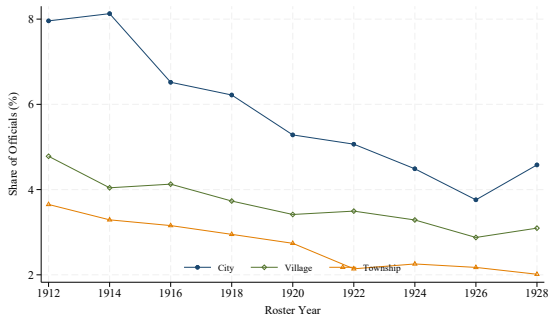
Township.	Names of Trustees.	Postoffice Address.
Bratton	Thomas Breslan	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	Gilbert Smily	Peebles, Ohio.
	C. W. Jones	Peebles, Ohio.
Franklin	R. T. Copeland	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
	H. F. Hirdman	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
	S. E. Stodgel	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
Green	M. H. Ralston	Stout, Ohio.
	A. W. Foster	Sandy Springs, Ohio.
	Adam Richter	Buena Vista, Ohio.
Jefferson	N. W. Cross	Wamsley, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	Clayton Moore	Wamsley, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	W. D. Vogler	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
Liberty	T. E. Shell	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 5.
	J. T. Moore	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	W. S. Jackson	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
Manchester	J. N. Matthews	Manchester, Ohio.
	Grimes N. Morgan	Manchester, Ohio.
	W. H. Gray	Manchester, Ohio.
Meigs	W. P. Newman	Peebles, Ohio.
	T. J. Newman	Rarden, Ohio.
	H. C. Wright	Peebles, Ohio.
Monroe	Homer Baldwin	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 5.
	James Clark	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	J. E. Young	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 4.
Oliver	Robbie Moore	West Union, Ohio.
	Earl Lewis	Peebles, Ohio.
	Wm. McClelland	West Union, Ohio.
Scott	J. C. McKenzie	Seaman, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	J. H. Plummer	Seaman, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	Jno. I. Cornelius	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
Sprigg	Charles Scott	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 3.
	C. C. Harover	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	Fred Kimble	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 3.
Tiffin	J. C. Crawford	West Union, Ohio.
	J. A. Craigmile	West Union, Ohio.
	Wm. Shumaker	West Union, Ohio.
Wayne	J. M. Kepperling	Cherry Fork, Ohio.
	Edward Siddens	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D.
	Ernest Shelton	Winchester, Ohio, R. F. D.
Winchester	R. C. Fulton	Winchester, Ohio.
	G. N. Baker	Winchester, Ohio.
	D. H. Pence	Winchester, Ohio.

Figure C3. Example page for township officials

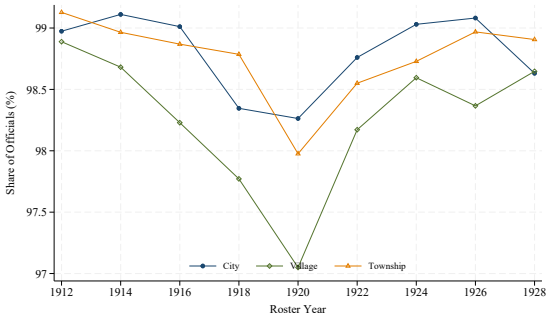
C.2 Who Are These Local Officials?



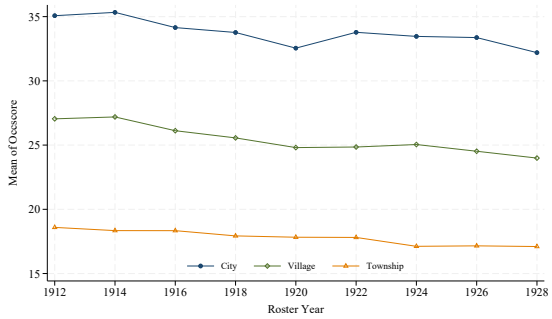
A. Male



B. Foreign born



C. Literacy



D. Pre-office occupational income score

Figure C4. Characteristics of Officials by Year

Note: This figure depicts the baseline characteristics of local officials by year and government format. Panels A, B, C, and D separately plot the trend of share of male officials, share of foreign-born officials, share of literate officials, and officials' average pre-office occupational income score.

D Validity of the Design

Table D1. Validity: Restricting to Officials First Observed After 1920

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.032***	0.027***	0.029***	-0.016**	-0.001	-0.005	
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.007)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.004						0.104***
	(0.008)						(0.026)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.382	22.382	0.214	0.147	0.394	0.240	1312.236
R^2	0.159	0.719	0.692	0.583	0.556	0.644	0.621
Observations	49555	49555	50815	50815	50815	50815	7949

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to sons of officials first observed entering office after 1920 and their matched controls. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

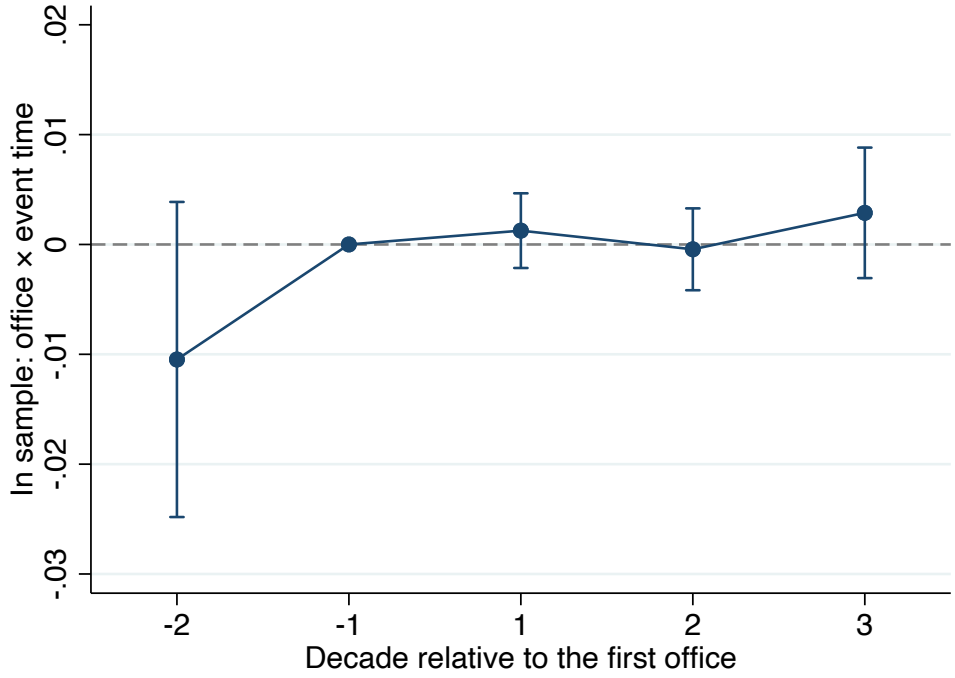


Figure D1. Dynamic Effect of Fathers' Officeholding on Sons' In-Sample Probability

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' in-sample probability from estimating Equation 2. The dependent variable equals one if the working-age son is in the main sample and zero otherwise. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

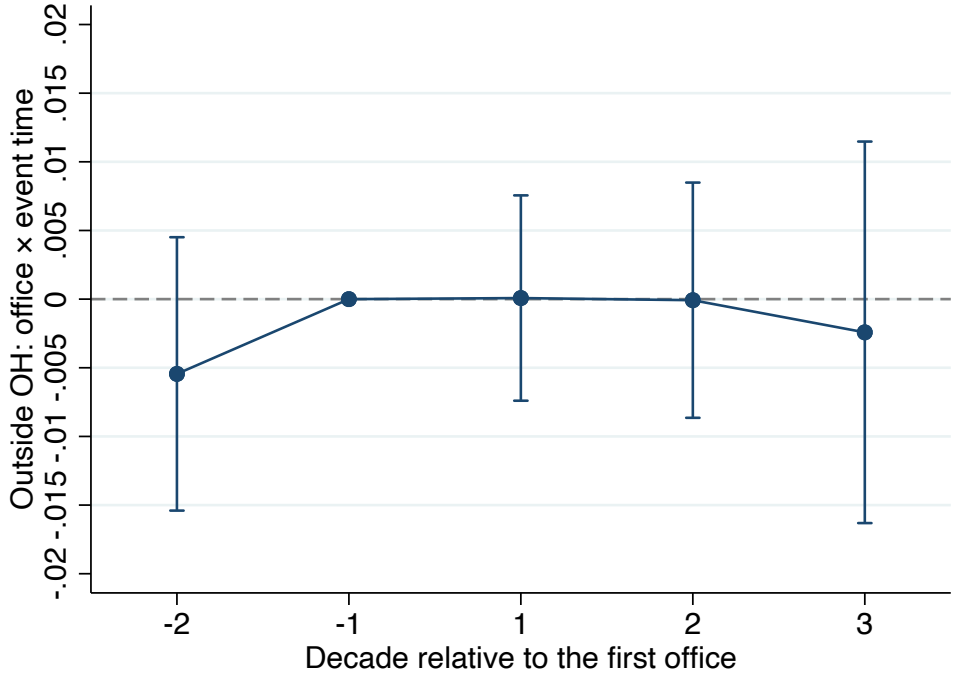


Figure D2. Dynamic Effect of Fathers' Officeholding on Sons' Probability of Residing Outside Ohio

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' probability of residing outside Ohio from estimating Equation 2. The dependent variable equals one if the son resides outside Ohio and zero if he resides in Ohio. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

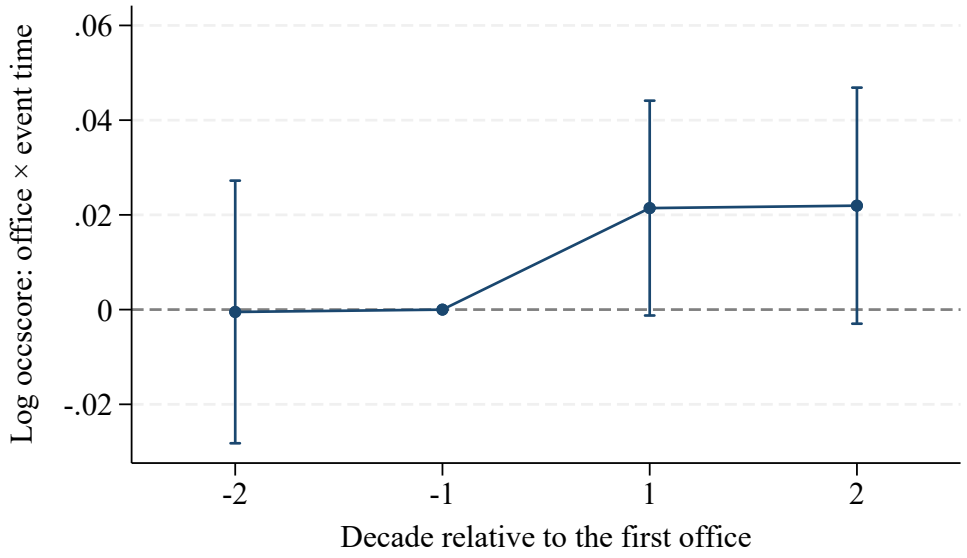


Figure D3. Balanced Sample: Dynamic Effect of Fathers' Officeholding on Sons' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income score from estimating Equation 2 in a fully balanced sample. Note that for individuals whose fathers started offices after 1920, there are only 2 post periods given the access to the full count census in 1940. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Table D2. Validity: Restricting to Young Sons

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.045***	0.039***	0.038***	-0.016**	-0.015	-0.004	
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.011)	(0.009)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	-0.008						0.095***
	(0.010)						(0.029)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	21.697	21.697	0.199	0.141	0.405	0.250	1292.504
R^2	0.180	0.726	0.697	0.586	0.562	0.640	0.598
Observations	44778	44778	45843	45843	45843	45843	7161

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to adult sons younger than age 28 when their fathers first enter office. Age 28 is the median age at fathers' office entry among officials' adult sons. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table D3. Validity: Excluding Potential Relatives from the Control Group

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.030***	0.023***	0.024***	-0.008	-0.003	-0.007	
	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)	(0.007)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.006						0.114***
	(0.008)						(0.029)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.401	22.401	0.210	0.148	0.392	0.243	1319.284
R^2	0.185	0.719	0.684	0.578	0.542	0.638	0.609
Observations	52514	52514	53907	53907	53907	53907	7221

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, reconstructing the matched sample after excluding potential controls who share a last name with any local official in the same county. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table D4. Validity: Excluding Officials with Only First-Name Initials Reported

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.019**	0.017*	0.008	-0.007	0.003	-0.005	
	(0.009)	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.010)	(0.008)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.000						0.127***
	(0.009)						(0.031)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.040	22.040	0.207	0.142	0.389	0.255	1279.132
R^2	0.174	0.710	0.677	0.567	0.546	0.635	0.627
Observations	43843	43843	44971	44971	44971	44971	6065

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to sons of officials whose full first names are reported in the rosters and their matched controls. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

E Intergenerational Impact of Office

E.1 Intergenerational Impact on Daughters

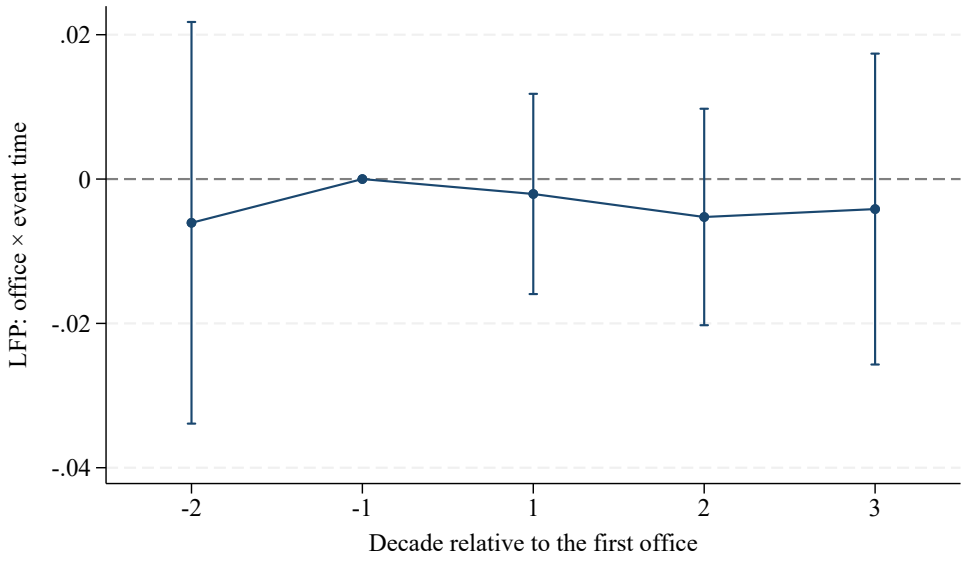


Figure E1. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Labor Force Participation

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' labor force participation from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.1.1 Daughters' Marital Outcomes

I then examine whether fathers' officeholding affects whom their daughters marry. To do so, I link daughters to their husbands in the census and get information on husbands' characteristics when she is first observed married. Because spousal characteristics are observed only for married women residing in the same household as their husbands, this analysis is restricted to matched daughters who are observed as married and residing in the same household as their husbands. Moreover, since each daughter is observed only once at the census in which she first appears as married, the data structure is cross-sectional rather than panel. For these marriage-related outcomes, I estimate the following equation:

$$y_{ibcmt} = \alpha_m + \beta_1(\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}) + \beta_2 \text{Post}_{it} + \beta_3 \text{Office}_i + \theta_b + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \quad \text{(E1)}$$

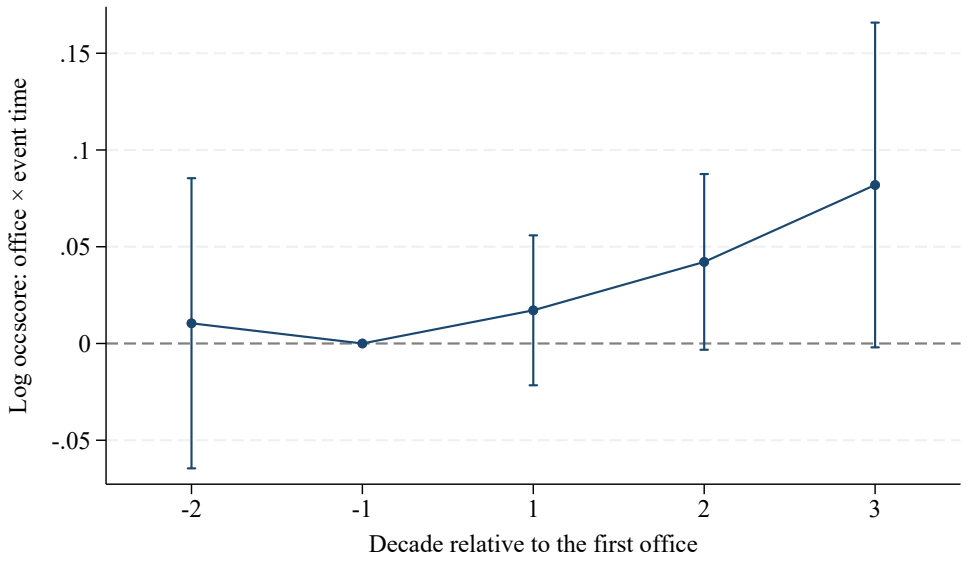


Figure E2. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' occupational income score from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes only working daughters. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

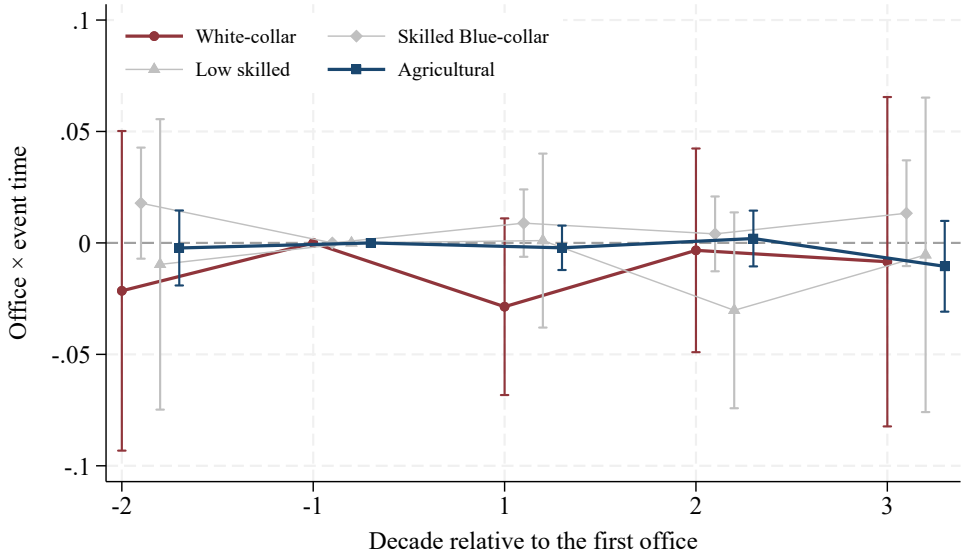


Figure E3. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Occupation

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' occupational categories from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

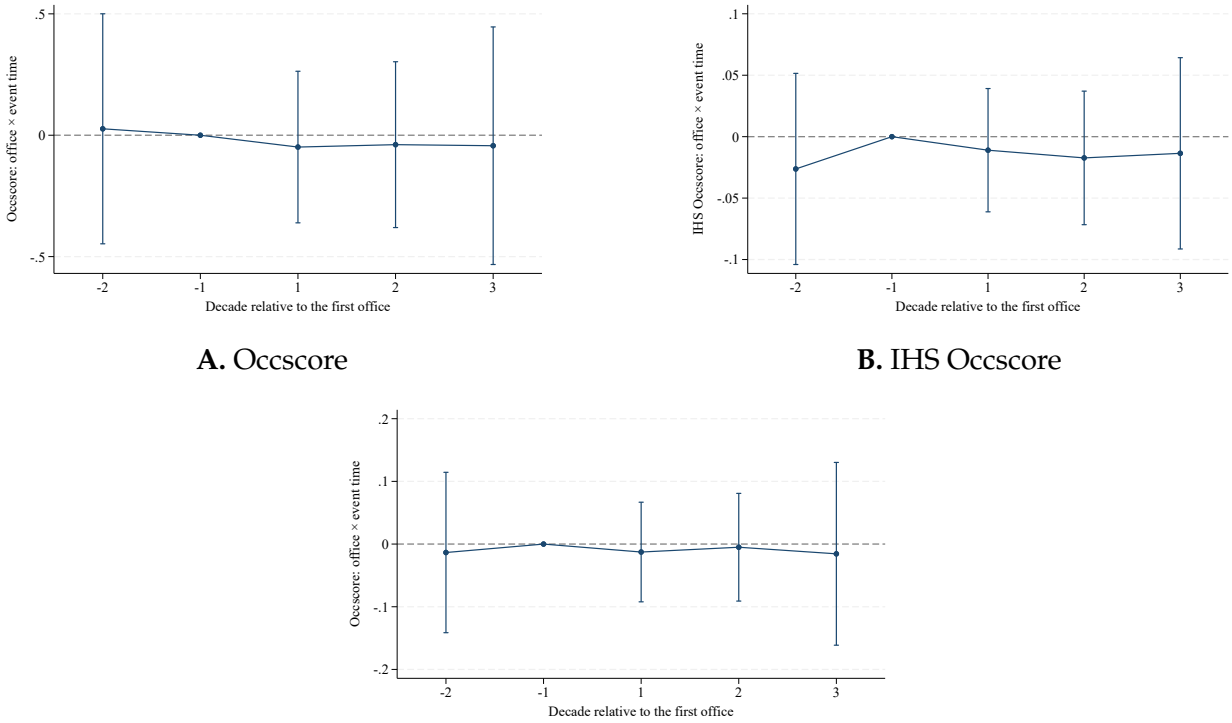
where m indexes the matched pairs generated in the matching procedure described in Section 3.1, and α_m denotes the matched pair fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the matched-pair level. The outcomes of interest, y_{ibcmt}, are husbands' characteristics

Table E1. Occupational Outcomes for All Daughters: Alternative Functional Forms

	(1) IHS	(2) Level	(3) PPML
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.008	-0.050	-0.007
	(0.023)	(0.142)	(0.035)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	3.205	3.205	3.205
R^2	0.517	0.531	
Observations	94853	94853	94853

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on daughters' occupational outcomes using alternative transformations and estimation methods. The unit of observation is the individual-census-year. Column (1) uses the inverse hyperbolic sine transformation of OCCSCORE and Column (2) uses levels of OCCSCORE. Column (3) estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) specification. All outcomes are defined for the full sample of daughters, with OCCSCORE set to zero for daughters who are not working. The sample includes matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed in the 1900–1940 Censuses. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post_{it} equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry; matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of OCCSCORE in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

when the daughter is first observed married, including occupation, occupational income score, and family background, proxied by the father-in-law's occupational income score.



A. Occscore

B. IHS Occscore

C. Occscore (PPML)

Figure E4. Occupational Outcomes for All Daughters: Alternative Functional Forms

Note: This figure presents event-study estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on unconditional occupational outcomes for daughters. The sample includes all matched daughters of working age, with OCCSCORE set to zero for daughters who are not working. Panel A uses OCCSCORE in levels, Panel B uses the inverse hyperbolic sine transformation of OCCSCORE, and Panel C estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood specification with OCCSCORE as the outcome. Event time is measured in census decades relative to the father's first entry into office, with the decade immediately preceding office entry omitted as the reference period. Points show coefficient estimates and bars indicate 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table E2. Intergenerational impact on daughters' marital outcomes

	Marital: Husband			
	(1) White collar	(2) Public sector	(3) Log Occscore	(4) Log Father Occscore
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.009	-0.002	0.071	-0.066
	(0.063)	(0.004)	(0.054)	(0.052)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Pair FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.144	0.001	20.085	17.539
R^2	0.580	0.582	0.630	0.602
Observations	9855	9855	9663	9395

Note: This table reports cross-sectional estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on daughters' marital matches. The sample consists of matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed married in at least one census between 1900 and 1940. Each daughter enters the sample once, using the first census in which she is observed married. The dependent variables are an indicator for the husband being employed in a white-collar occupation in Column (1), an indicator for the husband being employed in the public sector in Column (2), the log occupational income score (OCCSCORE) of the husband in Column (3), and the log OCCSCORE of the husband's father in Column (4). Office equals one if the daughter's father ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post equals one if the census in which the daughter is first observed married occurs after her father first enters office and zero otherwise; matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. All specifications include age-bin, matched-pair, county, and census-year fixed effects. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls. Standard errors are clustered at the matched-pair level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

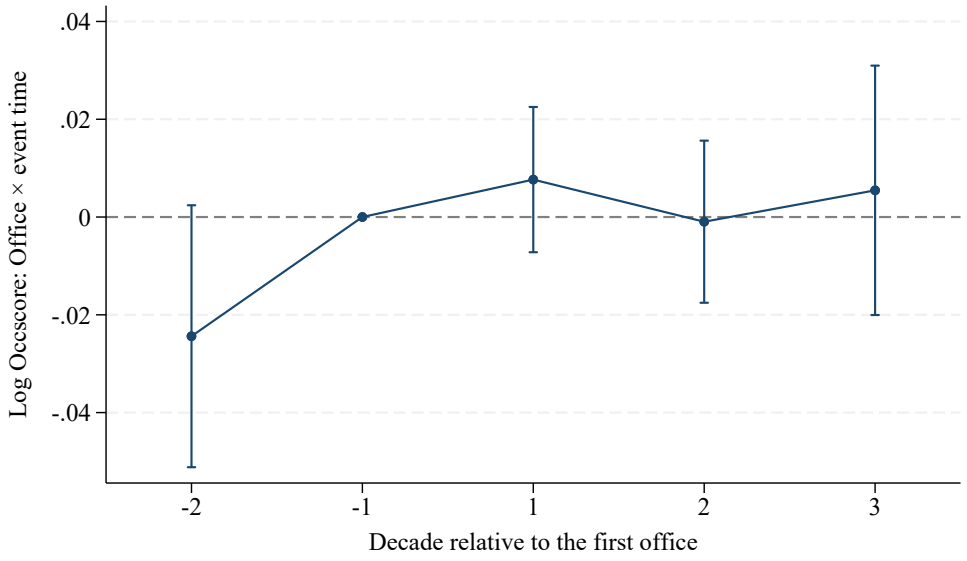


Figure E5. Dynamic Effects of Fathers-in-Law's Officeholding on Sons-in-Law's OCCSCORE

Note: This figure presents event-study estimates of the effect of fathers-in-law's officeholding on sons-in-law's occupational income scores from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes daughters and their matched counterparts who were married before their fathers start the offices. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.2 Heterogeneity of the Impact

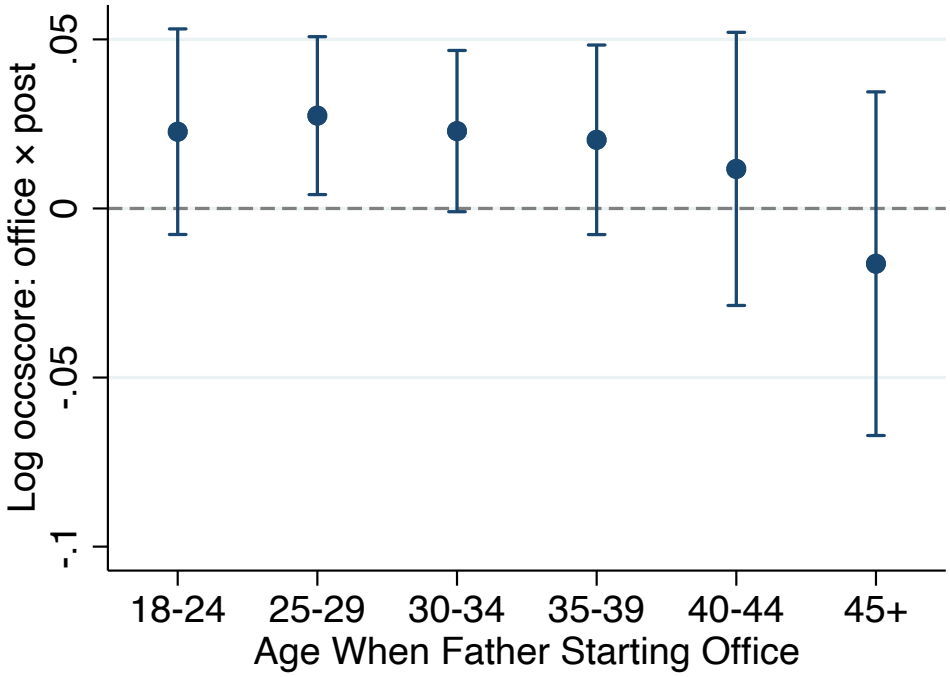


Figure E6. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Sons' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' log occupational income score by sons' age when their fathers first entered office. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

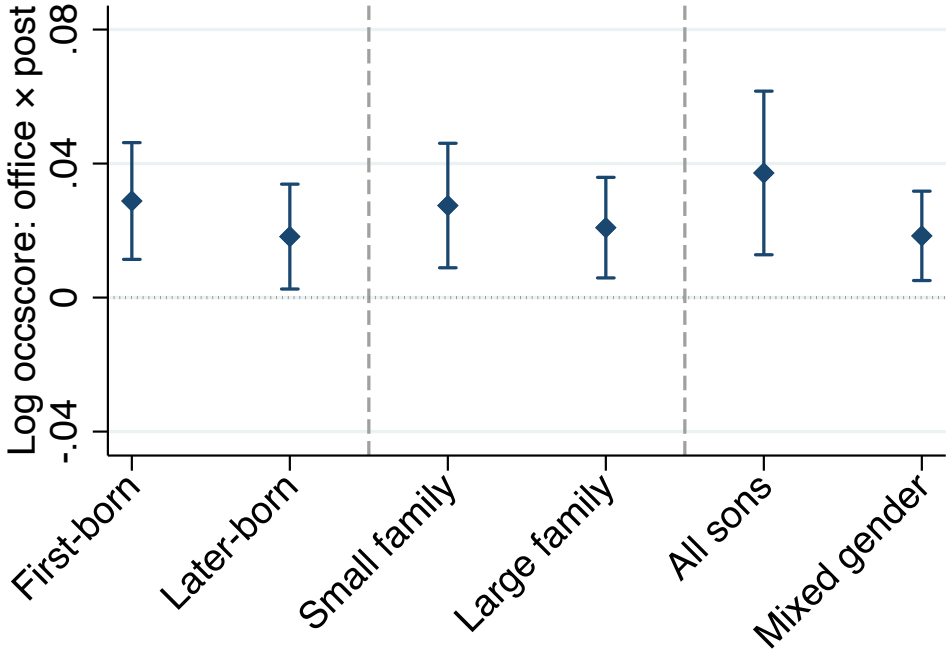


Figure E7. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Sons' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' log occupational income score by sibling composition. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

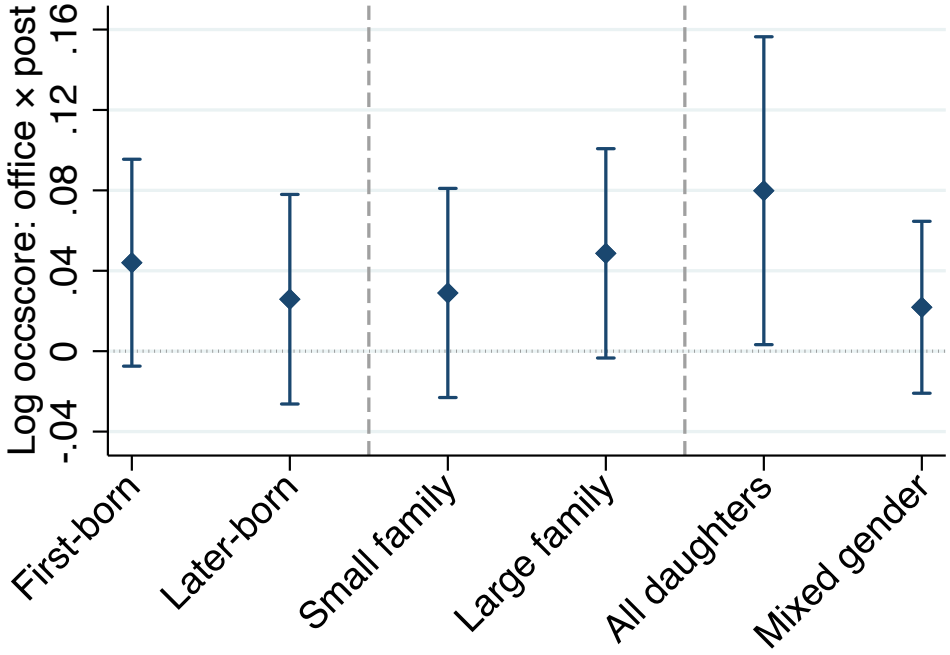


Figure E8. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Daughter's Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on working daughters' log occupational income score by sibling composition. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.3 Robustness Check

Table E3. Robustness: Alternative Inference

	Clustering at the level of			
	(1) Father	(2) Individual	(3) Matched pair	(4) County
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0229***	0.0229***	0.0229***	0.0229***
	(0.0062)	(0.0060)	(0.0062)	(0.0056)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	22.133	22.133	22.133	22.133
R^2	0.715	0.715	0.715	0.715
Observations	81981	81981	81981	81981

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' log occupational income score with standard errors clustered at different levels. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. The dependent variables are log occupational income score. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors in Column (1) to (4) are separately clustered at the level of fathers, the level of individuals, matched pairs, and counties.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table E4. Robustness: Alternative FE Specifications

	(1)	(2)	(3)
	logoccscore	logoccscore	logoccscore
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0229***	0.0195***	0.0188***
	(0.0062)	(0.0061)	(0.0053)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y		
Year FE	Y		
County-by-Year FE		Y	
Pair-by-Year FE			Y
Control Mean	22.133	22.133	22.133
R^2	0.715	0.717	0.888
Observations	81981	81981	81981

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' log occupational income score using alternative fixed effects specifications. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. The dependent variables are log occupational income score. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. Column (1) reports the baseline specification with county and census-year fixed effects. Column (2) replaces these fixed effects with pre-office-county-by-census-year fixed effects. Column (3) instead includes matched-pair-by-census-year fixed effects. The standard errors are clustered at the level of father.

* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table E5. Robustness: Alternative Outcome Measures and Specification

	IPUMS Occscore$_{it}$			LIDO Score$_{it}$		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Log	Level	PPML	Log	Level	PPML
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.023***	0.893***	0.040***	0.022***	0.580***	0.026***
	(0.006)	(0.174)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.164)	(0.008)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	22.133	20.261	20.261	22.260	20.880	20.880
R^2	0.715	0.605		0.672	0.590	
Observations	81981	89690	89690	73306	76363	76363

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income using different outcome measures (Columns (1), (2), (4), and (5)) and estimation specifications (Columns (3) and (6)). The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. The dependent variables for Columns (1) to (2) are log and level of occupational income score obtained from IPUMS; and for (4) to (5) are log and level of Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) score obtained from Saavedra and Twinam (2020). Note the sample size for LIDO score is smaller because Saavedra and Twinam (2020) constructed the score variable for individuals aged 25 and above. Columns (3) and (6) implement the Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (PPML) estimation on outcomes of OCCSCORE and LIDO score. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post$_{it}$ is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

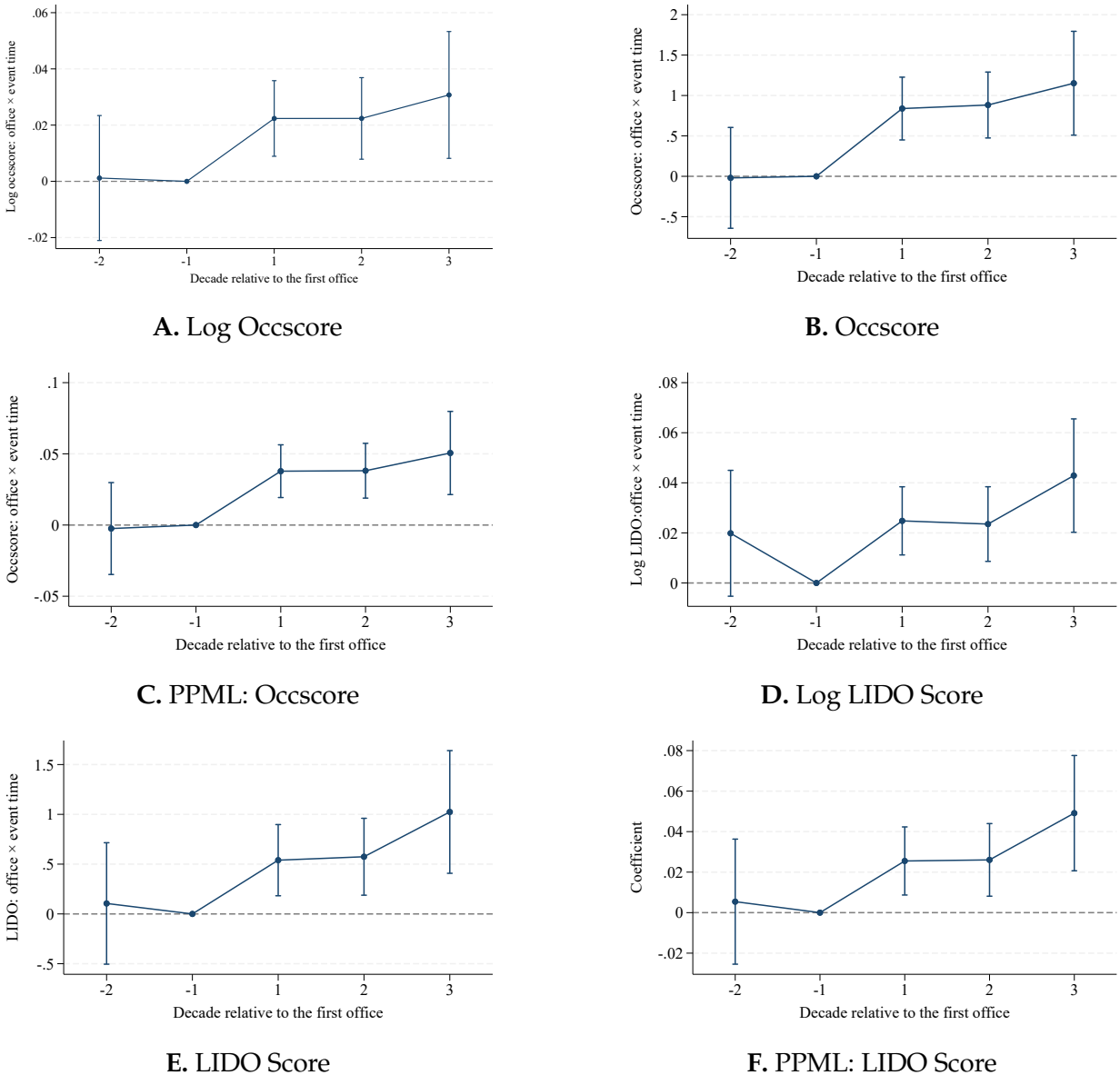


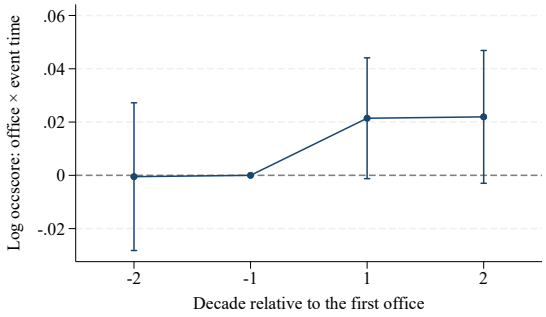
Figure E9. Robustness: Alternative Outcome Measures and Specification

Note: This figure presents the event study plots using alternative outcome measures and specifications. Panels A–C use occupational income score (OCCSCORE). Panel A uses log OCCSCORE, Panel B uses OCCSCORE in levels, and Panel C estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) specification. Panels D–F report the corresponding estimates using the Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) score from Saavedra and Twinam (2020) The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

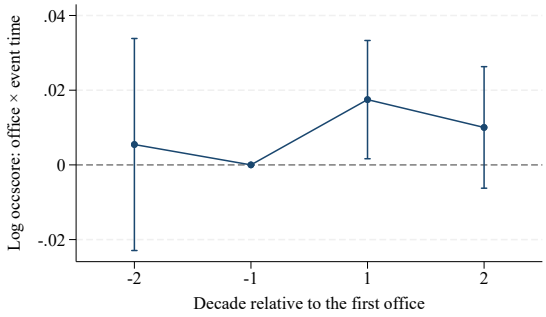
Table E6. Robustness: Alternative Sample

	(1) Balanced Panel	(2) Office 1914-1920	(3) Office 1920-1928
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.022**	0.022***	0.027***
	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Mean	22.921	22.624	23.075
R^2	0.715	0.712	0.719
Observations	20351	49928	49555

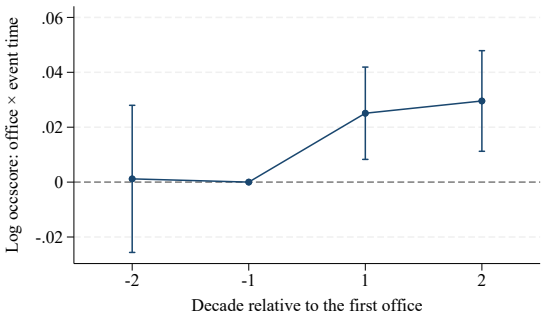
Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income using different samples. The dependent variables are log occupational income score. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Column (1) uses a fully balanced sample. Column (2) uses the sample of sons of officials who started their office between 1914 and 1920 and their matched counterparts. Column (3) uses the sample of sons of officials who started their office between 1920 and 1928 and their matched counterparts. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$



A. Balanced Panel



B. Office 1914-1920



C. Office 1920-1928

Figure E10. Robustness: Alternative Sample

Note: This figure presents the event study plots using alternative samples. Note that for individuals whose fathers started offices after 1920, there are only 2 post periods given the access to the full count census in 1940. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

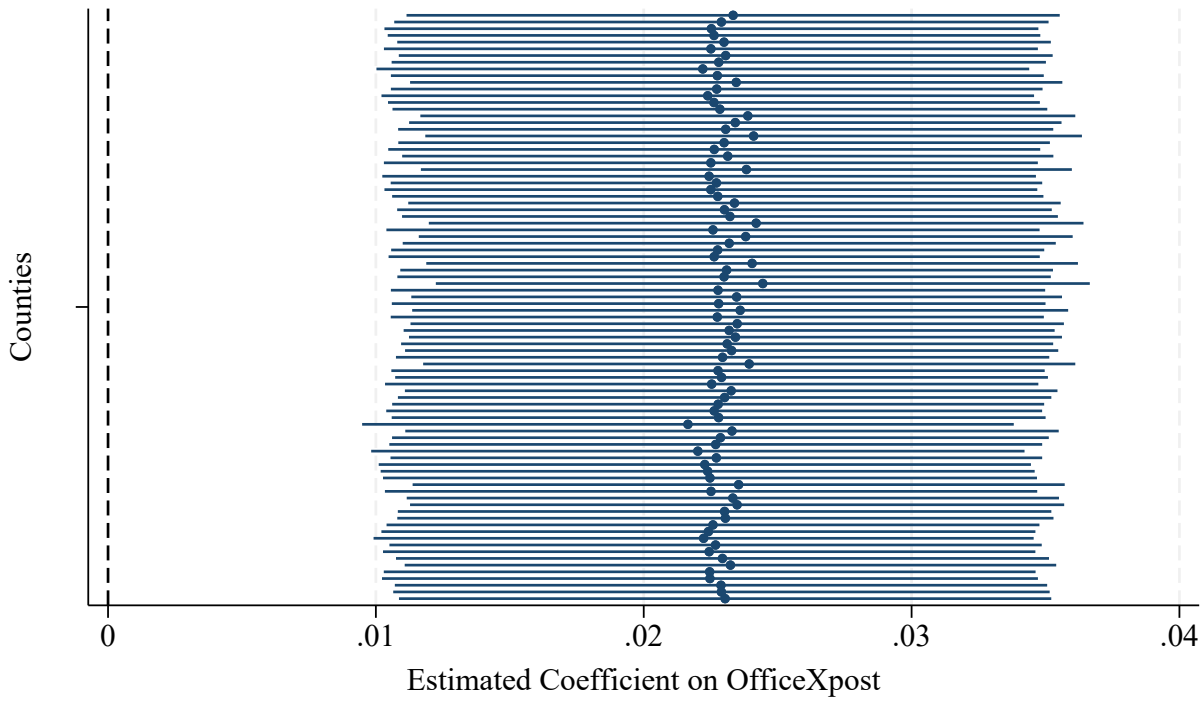


Figure E11. Robustness: Dropping One County Each Time

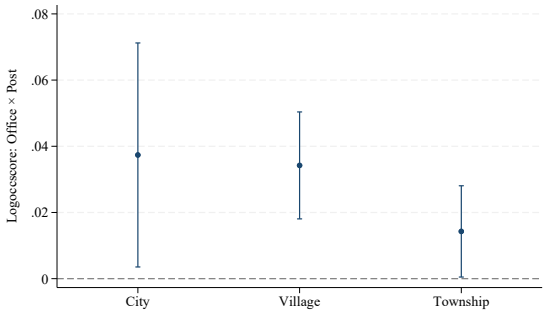
Note: This figure presents the coefficient on Office × Post from Equation 1, using the entire sample excluding one county at a time. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Table E7. Robust: Restricting to Officials in Core Elected Positions

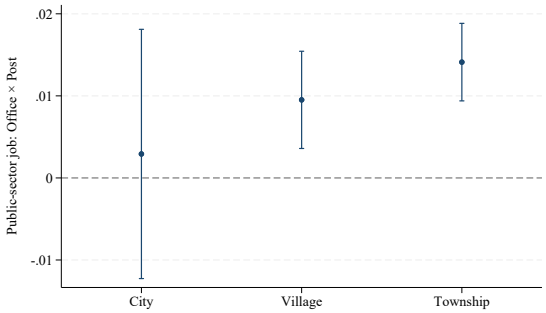
	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.019**	0.019***	0.019***	-0.009	-0.002	-0.003	
	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.008)	(0.007)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.003						0.127***
	(0.008)						(0.026)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	21.589	21.589	0.196	0.136	0.390	0.272	1255.471
R^2	0.166	0.708	0.681	0.572	0.541	0.632	0.611
Observations	66532	66532	68257	68257	68257	68257	8838

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to sons of officials in core elected positions and their matched controls. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individual–census-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

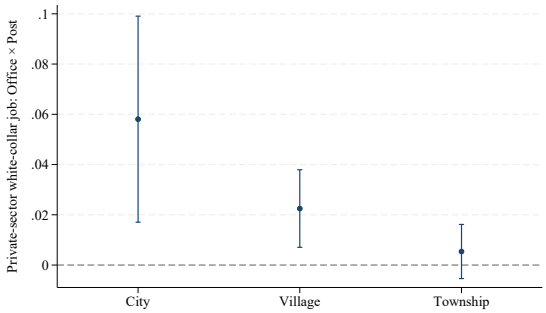
F Heterogeneity by Office



A. Occupational Income



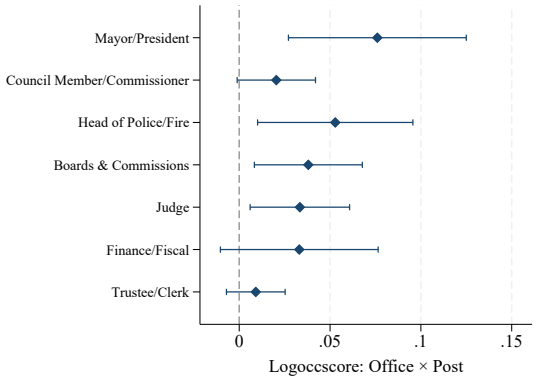
B. Public-sector Employment



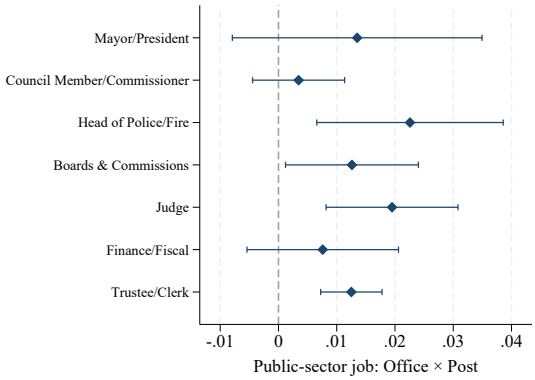
C. Private-sector White-collar Employment

Figure F1. Heterogeneity by Government

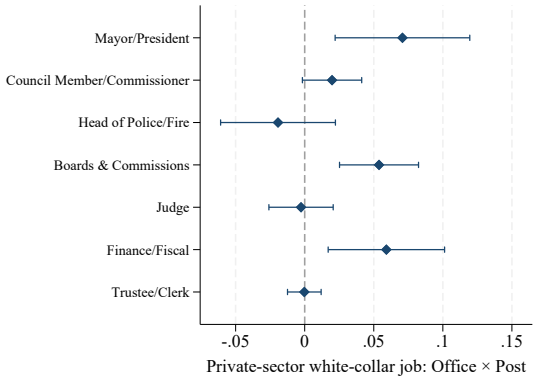
Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes across different governments. Panel A examines sons' log occupational income score, Panel B examines public-sector employment, and Panel C examines private-sector white-collar employment. The solid dots are point estimates, and the bars indicate 90 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.



A. Occupational Income



B. Public-sector Employment



C. Private-sector White-collar Employment

Figure F2. Heterogeneity by Fathers' Office Type

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes across broad categories of local offices. Panel A examines sons' log occupational income score, Panel B examines public-sector employment, and Panel C examines private-sector white-collar employment. The solid dots are point estimates, and the bars indicate 90 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

G Other Potential Mechanisms

Table G1. Testing Occupational Inheritance

	Broad category		Detailed category	
	(1) Same industry	(2) Same occupation	(3) Same industry	(4) Same occupation
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.006	0.005	-0.001	0.007
	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Mean	0.408	0.298	0.376	0.260
R^2	0.626	0.555	0.648	0.571
Observations	89690	89690	89690	89690

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of working in their fathers' pre-office ($t = -1$) jobs. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in their father's pre-office industry (Columns (1) and (3)) or occupation (Columns (2) and (4)). Columns (1) and (2) use the broader definition of industry and occupation, while Columns (3) and (4) use the finest definition of industry and occupation provided in IND1950 and OCC1950 variable in Censuses. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table G2. Testing Marriage Network

	Wife's Father		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Log occscore	White-collar	Public sector
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.048	-0.017	-0.001
	(0.043)	(0.037)	(0.007)
$\text{Office}_{j(i)}$	0.016	0.023*	0.003
	(0.016)	(0.012)	(0.004)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
Pair FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Mean	18.788	0.096	0.007
R^2	0.625	0.591	0.579
Observations	8768	9005	8733

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' marital outcomes. The sample consists of married individuals and are therefore cross-sectional. Columns (1) to (3) examine characteristics of the wife's family in the first census where the son is observed as married: the log occupational income score (occscore) of the wife's father, whether the wife's father works in white-collar jobs, and whether the wife's father works in the public sector. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the match pair level.

Table G3. Testing Reputation Channel

	Log Occupational Income		Public-sector		Private-sector White-collar	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Common	Rare	Common	Rare	Common	Rare
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.024***	0.020**	0.014***	0.009***	0.012	0.019**
	(0.008)	(0.009)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Mean	22.7595	22.9564	0.0207	0.0236	0.2104	0.2209
R^2	0.7129	0.7171	0.4947	0.5229	0.6342	0.6392
Observations	39055	39850	41990	42774	41990	42774

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income and probability of public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar employment by the frequency of their last names. The dependent variables for Columns (1) and (2) are sons' log occupational income score; for Columns (3) and (4) are binary variables equal to one if officials' sons work in the public sector; and for Columns (5) and (6) are binary variables equal to one if officials' sons work in white-collar jobs in the private sector. Samples in Columns (1), (3), and (5) include sons of officials with common surnames defined by surname frequency larger than the median of the surname frequency among the sample; while Columns (2), (4), and (6) include sons of officials with less common surnames defined by surname frequency lower than the median of the surname frequency in the sample. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

H Exploring the Downstream Effects

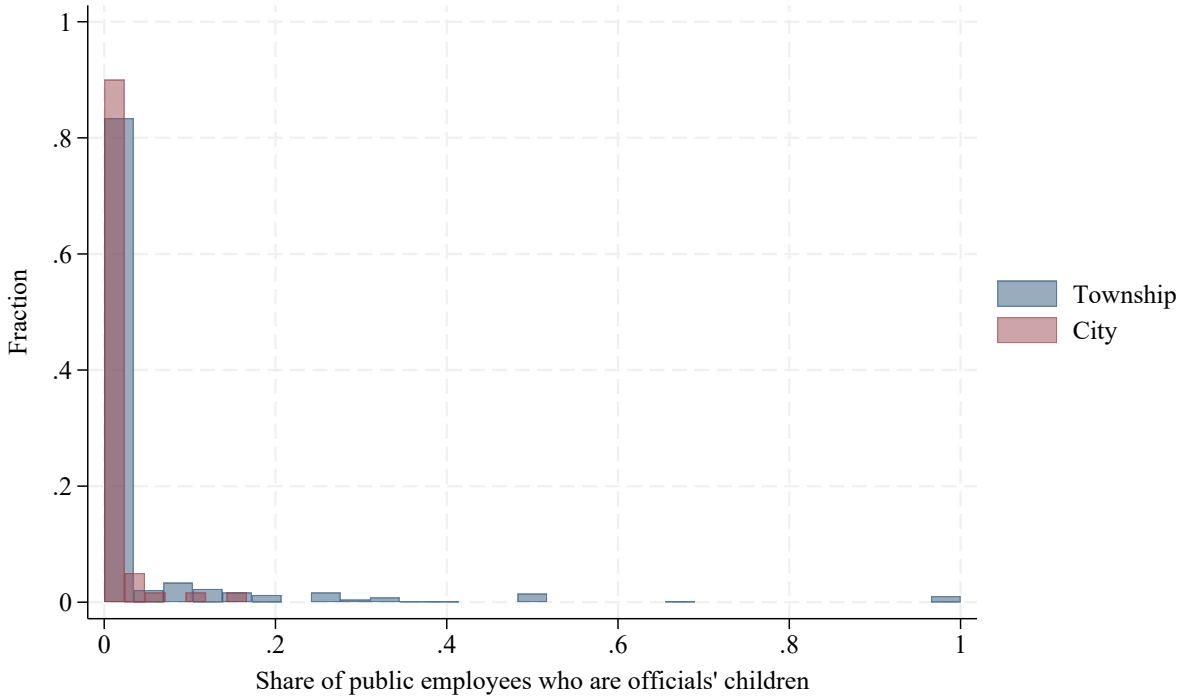


Figure H1. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector (Full Sample)

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample does not have any restriction on the size of public sector employees.

Table H1. Downstream Effect of Intergenerational Political Advantage (Full Sample)

	Township				City			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share
Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)	0.005**		0.005*		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.002)		(0.003)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.020***		0.020***		-0.007		0.004
		(0.006)		(0.006)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.612	0.612	0.376	0.376	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.646	0.648	0.582	0.585	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	957	957	957	957	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). "Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)" is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

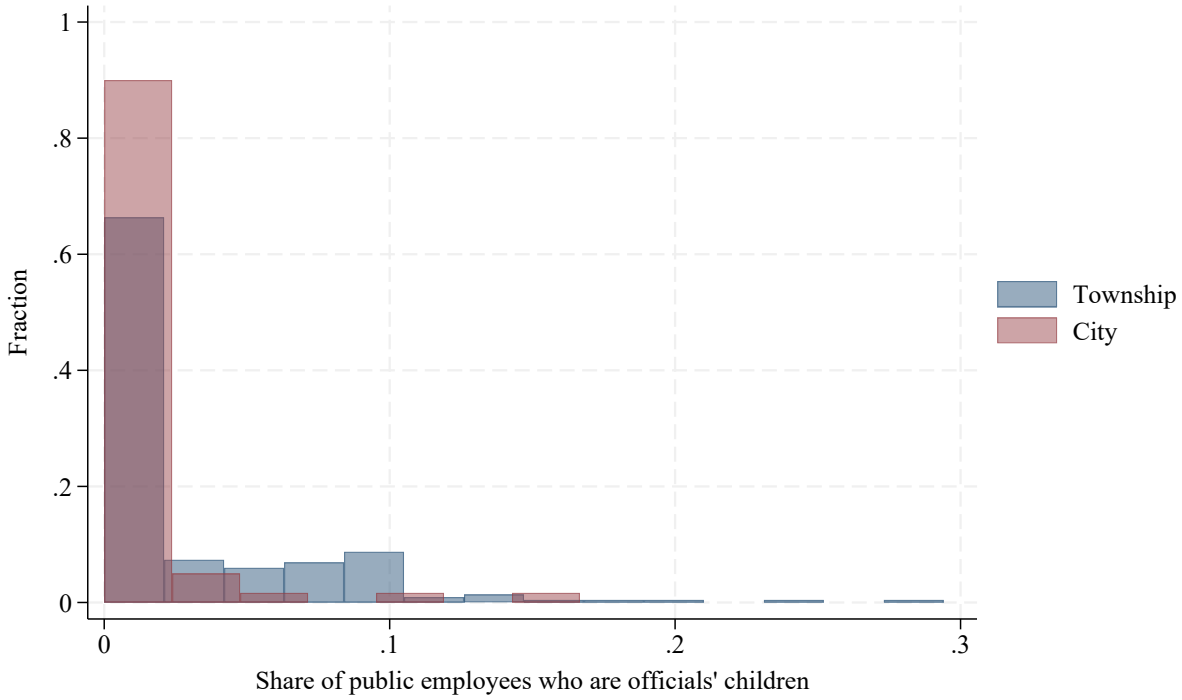


Figure H2. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector ($\geq$ 10 public employees)

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample is restricted to localities with at least ten public-sector employees observed in the 1930 Census.

Table H2. Downstream Effect of Intergenerational Political Advantage ($\geq$ 10 public employees)

	Township				City			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share
Share of politicians' sons in pub (sd)	0.015		0.021*		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.013)		(0.011)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.015*		0.021***		-0.007		0.004
		(0.009)		(0.007)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.552	0.552	0.323	0.323	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.656	0.658	0.577	0.585	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	217	217	217	217	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. The sample includes cities and townships with public employees size at least 10. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). "Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)" is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.